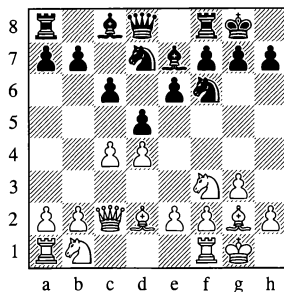


Chapter 14

Catalan 4...♖b4†



5...♖e7 – Main Line

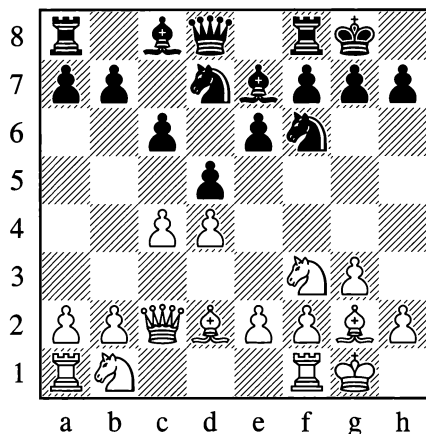
Variation Index

1.d4 ♘f6 2.c4 e6 3.g3 d5 4.♘f3 ♖b4† 5.♙d2 ♙e7 6.♙g2 0–0 7.0–0 c6
8.♚c2 ♘bd7

9.♙f4

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1.d4 ♘f6 2.c4 e6 3.g3 d5 4.♘f3 ♗b4† 5.♗d2
 ♗e7 6.♗g2 0-0 7.0-0 c6 8.♖c2 ♘bd7



This is Black's most popular set-up.

9.♗f4

Improving the bishop seems most logical to me. Black has three main ideas: A) 9...♘h5, B) 9...a5 and C) 9...b6.

A) 9...♘h5 10.♗c1 f5

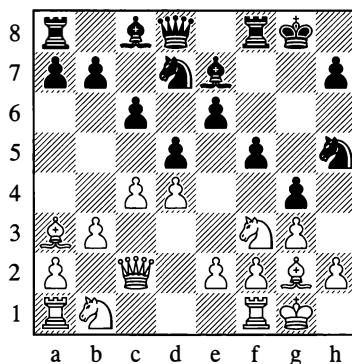
10...♘hf6 transposes to variation B2 of the next chapter, with three extra moves played, after which 11.♘bd2 reminds us of why the bishop is better on c1 than d2.

11.b3 ♗d6

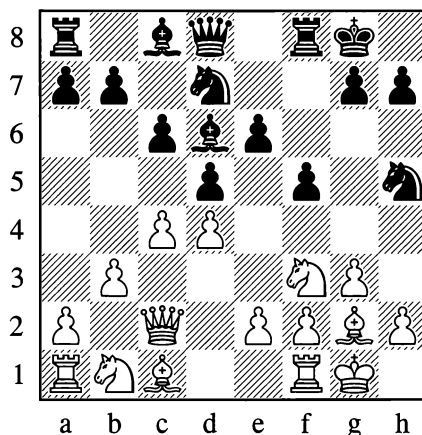
Black has tried numerous other moves, but in most lines White keeps a typical edge, as is the case in most Stonewall positions with the bishop on e7 rather than d6. I decided not to devote too much space to this section, as I don't see any special way for Black to make use of the ...♘h5 move. Moreover, I think the probability of encountering this line is pretty low since, if Black really wanted to play a Stonewall structure, he could have just played a Dutch in the first place.

If Black is going to try and make use of the

knight on h5, then the most interesting opportunity is 11...g5. White should simply carry out his main positional plan of trading the dark-squared bishops: 12.♗a3 (In *GM 1* I gave 12.e3, but I subsequently realized that after 12...g4 13.♘e5 ♘hf6!, as in Jirka – Kaspi, Israel 2012, White is deprived of the crucial plan of opening the centre with f2-f3 and e3-e4) 12...g4



This occurred in Antic – Maksimovic, Vrnjacka Banja 1998, and now the simple 13.♘e1N would have been good for White. It is important to realize that 13...f4 is no problem, as 14.♘d3 ♗xa3 15.♘xa3 ♖f6 16.♖c3 keeps everything under control for White.



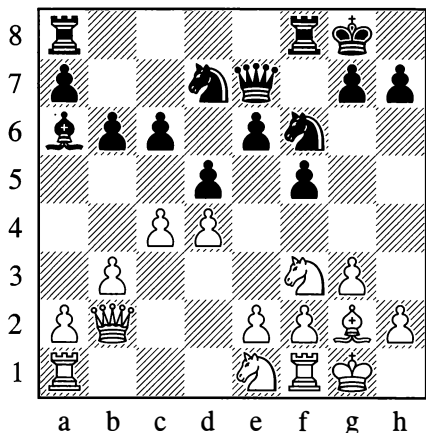
12.♗a3 ♗xa3 13.♘xa3 ♖e7 14.♖b2 ♘hf6

Another game continued: 14...b6 15.♘c2

♙b7 16.a4 (16.♖ce1 allows 16...dxc4! 17.bxc4 c5 when Black is fine) 16...a5 17.♖e5 ♖hf6 18.♖d3 ♜ac8 19.♖e3!? A slightly surprising square for the knight, but from this spot it restrains Black's central pawn breaks. 19...♖e4 20.♜ac1 White maintained a slight edge in Evans – Petters, Internet 2011.

15.♖c2 b6 16.♖ce1 ♙a6

Even after the more accurate 16...♙b7N 17.♖d3 dxc4 (17...c5 18.cxd5 ♙xd5 19.♜ac1± also favours White) 18.bxc4 c5 19.e3 ♜ac8 20.♜ac1 White's position remains slightly more pleasant.



17.♜c1 ♖e4 18.♖d3 ♜ac8 19.♖fe5 ♖df6?

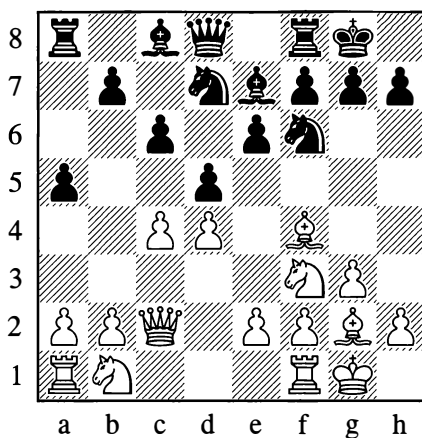
This occurred in Nyback – Yusupov, Puhajarve 2011, and here both players overlooked an important resource for White:

20.c5!N

Putting serious pressure on Black's queenside.

B) 9...a5

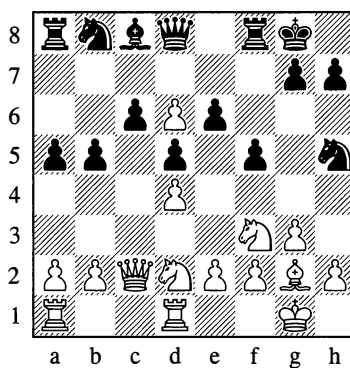
This was played in a bunch of games in the 1990s, but it became more fashionable after Topalov employed it against Kramnik in the 2006 World Championship. It has been played many times since *GM 1* was published.



10.♜d1 ♖h5

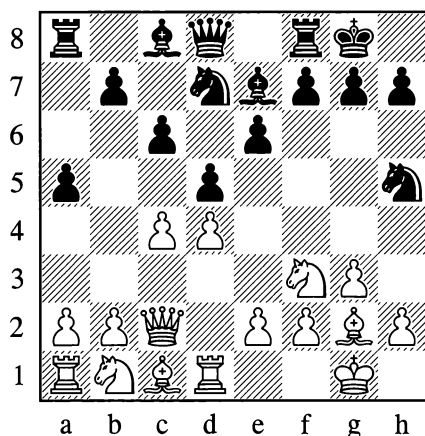
It may seem strange to make two consecutive moves on opposite flanks, but the logic will soon become clear.

10...b5 has scored amazingly well for Black, but White has a good answer: 11.c5 ♖h5 12.♙d6! This implies a pawn sacrifice, but White gets some significant positional trumps in return. 12...♙xd6 13.cxd6 ♖b8 (I also considered 13...♙b7N 14.♖bd2 ♜b8 15.e4 ♜xd6 16.e5 ♜e7 17.♖b3 a4 18.♖c5 ♖xc5 19.dxc5 when White's compensation is obvious) 14.♖bd2 f5 Here it is easy to improve White's play from Meier – Postny, Copenhagen 2010.



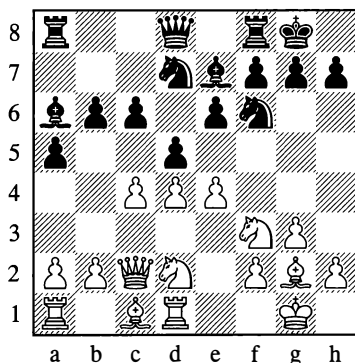
15.♜c5!N ♖f6 16.♖e5 ♖e8 (16...♖fd7 17.♜c2 ♖f6 18.♖xc6 ♜xd6 19.♖xb8 ♜xb8 20.♖b3 leaves White with a small but stable edge.) 17.d7! ♙xd7 18.♜ac1 White has a lot of compensation.

11.♙c1



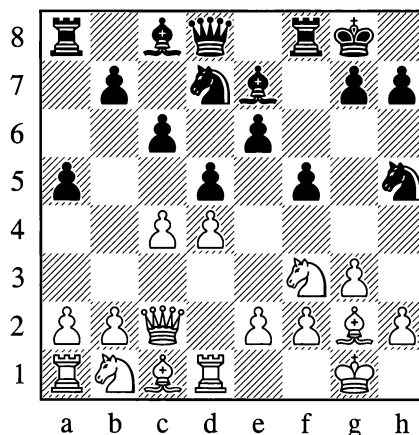
From this position **B1) 11...f5** has scored well for Black and deserves attention, but the main line is **B2) 11...b5**.

11...♘hf6 12.♘bd2 allows White to play a quick e2-e4, which is usually an indication that the opening has gone well for him. 12...b6 (12...b5 is well met by 13.c5!, for instance 13...♙e8 14.e4 ♘xe4 15.♘xe4 dxe4 16.♙xe4 ♘f6 17.♙c2± and White got a typical advantage thanks to Black's long-term problem with the light-squared bishop, Marin – Pogorelov, Barcelona 1993.) 13.e4 ♙a6 Now White should not rush to take action in the centre, but should instead take a moment to consolidate.



14.b3!N (After the hasty 14.e5 ♘e8 15.♙f1

♘c7 16.♙d3 h6 Black was all right in Colon Garcia – Potkin, Barcelona 2013) 14...♙c8 15.e5 ♘e8 16.♘f1! With the c4-pawn secure, White can bring his knight to the ideal e3-square. 16...c5 17.dxc5 ♘xc5 18.♘e3 ♘c7 19.♘d4 Black is under pressure.

B1) 11...f5

It is quite reasonable for Black to switch to a Stonewall structure before taking action on the queenside.

12.♘c3!?

12.b3 ♘hf6 was not so special for White in Wempe – L'Ami, Dieren 2013. Since Black has already weakened his queenside position with ...a5, it makes a lot of sense to bring the white knight to a4 in some positions.

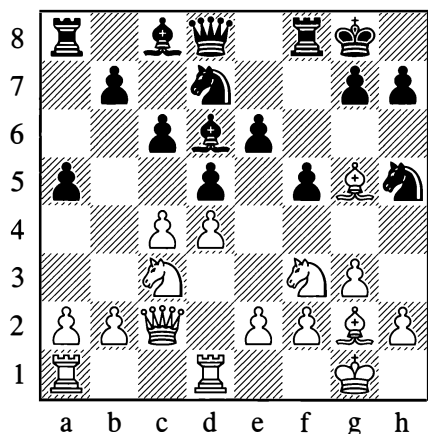
12...♙d6

12...dxc4N 13.e4 promises White a lot of compensation for the pawn.

12...b6N 13.♘e5 ♙b7 14.♘xd7 ♙xd7 15.♘a4! looks unpleasant for Black.

13.♙g5

13.♘a4N ♘hf6 14.c5 ♙c7 15.♙f4!? also deserves consideration.



13...♙e8 14.♙e3!

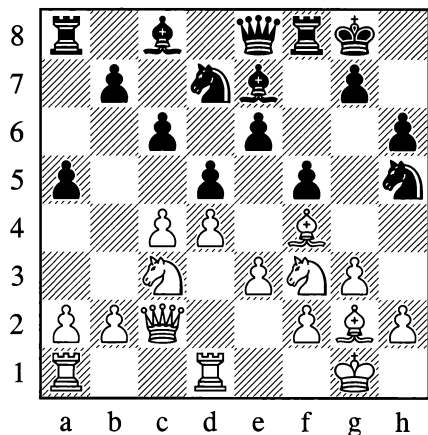
The idea is to play ♙f4 and, after Black takes, to recapture with the e-pawn, changing the structure in White's favour.

14...h6

I also considered 14...♖b8N 15.c5 ♙c7 16.♙f4 e5 17.dxe5 ♘xe5 18.♘xe5 ♙xe5 19.♙xe5 ♗xe5 20.♘a4 when the weak a5-pawn will give Black headaches.

15.♙f4 ♙e7

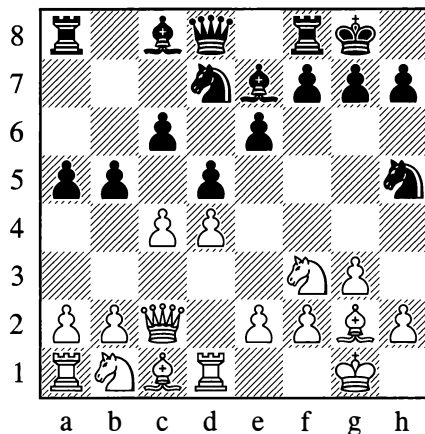
Now in Rahman – Adhiban, Sharjah 2014, I believe White should have played:



16.♙c7! N ♘hf6 17.c5 ♙d8 18.♙xd8 ♗xd8 19.♘a4

Once again, White has clear ideas to seize the initiative on the queenside, thanks to the weakening ...a5 move.

B2) 11...b5



Before setting up the Stonewall, Black first intends to clarify the situation on the queenside.

12.♘e5!

I believe this is White's only chance to fight for an advantage. In the event of 12.c5 f5 Black has a solid position and does not have to worry about his queenside like he did in the previous variation.

After 12.cxd5 cxd5 13.e4 dxe4 14.♗xe4 ♖b8 White has scored well, but it seems to me that Black is okay. See, for instance, Radjabov – Topalov, Wijk aan Zee 2007, where the former World Champion improved on Game 10 of his famous match encounter against Kramnik.

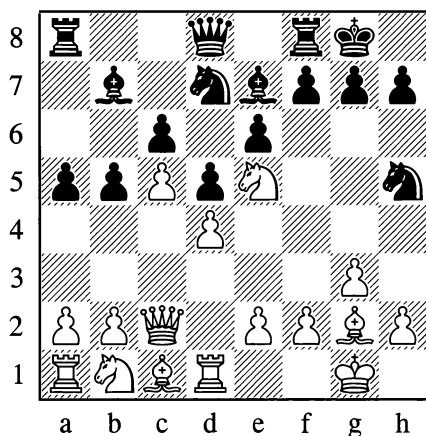
12...♙b7

Black has no time for 12...♘xe5 13.dxe5 bxc4?, as 14.g4 traps the knight.

13.c5

White has also tried 13.♘xd7 ♗xd7 14.c5 f5 15.♘d2 ♗c7 16.♘f3 ♙f6, as in Gelfand –

Kamsky, Sochi 2008. At this point GM Lysyj pointed out that 17.♞c3N would have retained an edge for White, thanks to the positional idea of ♞e3 followed by ♜e5. Nevertheless, I believe it is more promising for White to keep both pairs of knights.



13...f5

Black has also tried doing without this move by means of 13...g6 14.♙h6 ♜g7 in Bromberger – Onischuk, Bavaria 2010. Here the simple 15.♜xd7N ♞xd7 16.♜d2 f5 17.a3! would have kept some advantage. The last move is a useful way to prepare future ideas on the queenside. For instance, White may attack the a5-pawn to provoke ...a4, and later open things up with b2-b3.

14.♜d2 ♜hf6

After 14...♜xe5 15.dxe5± Black's knight has no good route into the game, and White has a clear plan of strengthening his position by transferring his knight to d4. Black's position remains solid but passive.

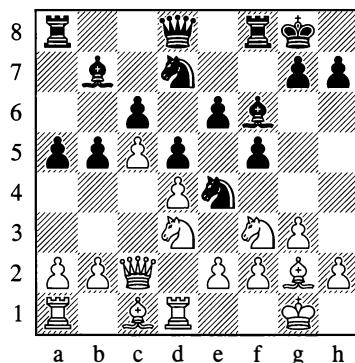
15.♜d3

This is the proper moment to remove the knight from the centre, as Black was threatening to exchange it and retreat the other knight to d7.

15...♞e8

Defending against a possible ♜f4.

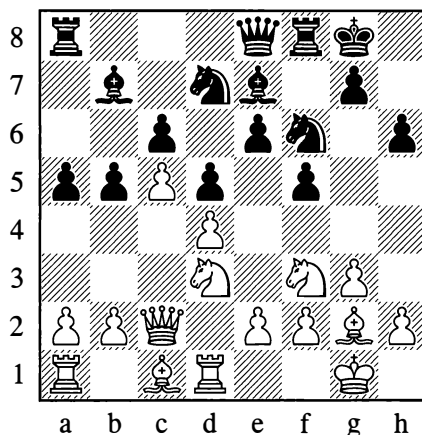
Black's most recent try was 15...♜e4 16.♜f3 ♙f6, Wagner – Banusz, Sibenik 2012. White should be able to claim a positional edge in any case, but the move I like most is:



17.a3!N This flexible move prevents Black's idea of ...b4 and ...♙a6 to activate the bishop. 17...♞e7 (17...g5 runs into the unpleasant 18.♜fe5! followed by f2-f3) 18.♙f4 g5 19.♙e5 g4 20.♙xf6 ♜exf6 21.♜fe5 White retains a pleasant edge.

16.♜f3 h6

Now in Miroshnichenko – Macieja, Halkidiki 2008, White should have played:



17.♙f4N g5

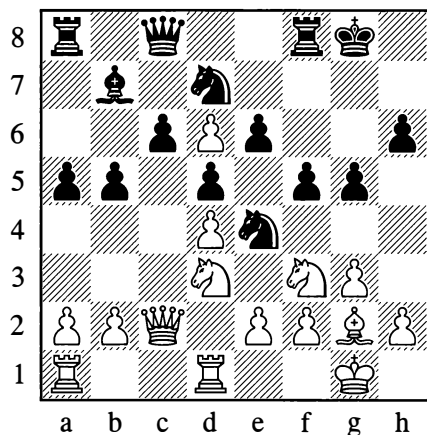
17...♗e4 18.♗fe5 ♗xe5 19.♙xe5 looks excellent for White, who can confidently make all the necessary preparations for the e2-e4 advance.

The text move is probably what White was concerned about, but there is a good answer available.

18.♙c7!?

With the following point:

18...♞c8 19.♙d6! ♙xd6 20.cxd6 ♗e4



21.♗c5 ♗xd6 22.♗xe6 ♞f6 23.♗c5 ♗xc5 24.♞xc5

White has a clear positional advantage. There is even an interesting alternative in 24.dxc5! followed by ♗d4.

C) 9...b6

This is the most important and popular set-up.

10.♞d1

Now Black must make an important choice between C1) 10...♙a6 and C2) 10...♙b7.

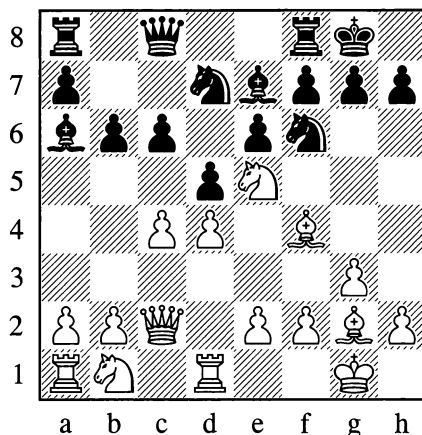
C1) 10...♙a6 11.♗e5

It is important to start with this move, since 11.cxd5 cxd5 12.♗e5 allows Black an

important additional possibility in 12...♗xe5 13.dxe5 ♞c8 (or 13...♗g4 immediately) 14.♗c3 ♗g4, as played in Anand – Topalov, Nanjing 2010.

Black may respond with C11) 11...♞c8, C12) 11...♗xe5 or C13) 11...♞c8.

C11) 11...♞c8



12.♗c3

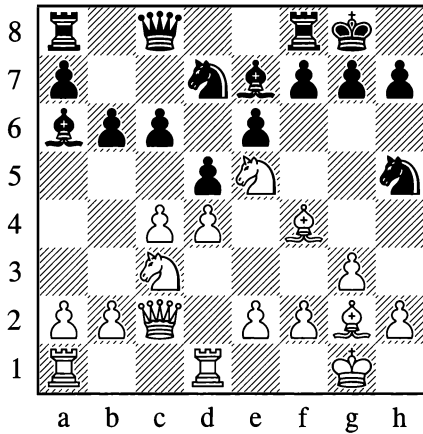
12.cxd5 cxd5 13.♗c6 allows the tactical trick 13...♙c5! 14.♞xc5 bxc5 15.♗e7† ♖h8 16.♗xc8 ♞fxc8= when Black is fine.

12...♗h5!?

The knight jump is a common motif in such positions.

12...♙xc4 13.♗xc4 dxc4 has occurred in several games, but I am not so concerned about this. After 14.♗e4 b5 15.♗d6 ♙xd6 16.♙xd6 ♞d8 17.a4 White's strong pair of bishops gave him excellent compensation in Wojtkiewicz – Zubarev, Moscow 2002.

White retreated the bishop to e3 in Sambuev – Smirnov, Krasnoyarsk 2003, and one other game, but I believe Black is okay after returning with the knight to f6. That is why I developed another plan.

**13.♙d2?N**

The bishop is less vulnerable here than on e3, which makes a difference in certain lines.

13...♘hf6

An obvious alternative is 13...♘xe5 14.dxe5, when Black has to play 14...g6 to rescue his knight. 15.cxd5 cxd5 (15...exd5?! 16.♙ac1 leaves White with a lot of pressure) 16.♙h6 (16.♙a4!? looks interesting as well) 16...♙d8 17.♙d2 ♖g7 18.♙ad1 White's pieces are much better coordinated, and he should be able to carry out e2-e4 in the near future.

14.♙a4! ♘xe5

14...♙b7 15.♙ac1 obviously cannot be good for Black.

15.dxe5 ♘d7

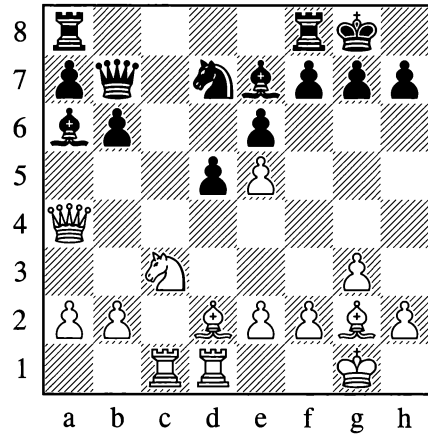
15...♘g4 would have been an annoying reply in the analogous line with the bishop on e3, but here 16.cxd5 exd5 17.♙h3 h5 18.f3 b5 19.♙c2 ♙c5† 20.♘g2 favours White. Even though the black knight cannot be captured immediately, the pin looks pretty awkward for Black.

16.cxd5 cxd5

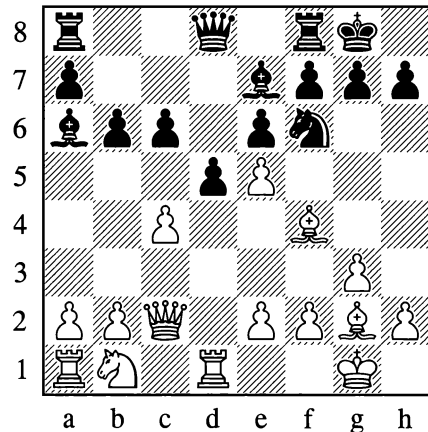
16...exd5 runs into 17.♙h3! ♙d8 18.e6 fxe6 19.♙xe6† ♘h8 20.♙e3 with White's advantage.

17.♙ac1 ♙b7

Now White can exploit the awkward position of the enemy queen with the following forcing continuation.

**18.♙e3 b5 19.♘xd5! exd5 20.♙xd5 ♙xd5 21.♙xa6 ♘b8 22.♙xd5 ♘xa6 23.♙xb5**

The arising endgame is difficult for Black.

C12) 11...♘xe5 12.dxe5

Exchanging knights is a principled reaction.

12...♘d7

12...♘h5? is clearly inferior, and 13.♙e3 already threatens to win the knight. After the further 13...f5 14.cxd5 cxd5 15.♘c3± Black has an unpleasant position due to the

misplaced knight, Tkachiev – Tukmakov, Porec 1998.

Also risky is:

12...♘g4 13.♙f3!N

This move is new, but somehow I have a feeling that many players who have worked on this variation are aware of it.

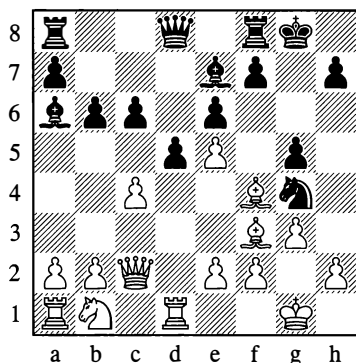
It is essential to understand the problem with 13.h3. A recent example continued 13...♘xf2! 14.♙xf2 ♙c5† 15.♙e3 ♙xe3† 16.♙xe3 ♖g5† 17.♙f2 f6 with promising counterplay, Shaydullina – Kovalenko, Khanty-Mansiysk 2013.

13...g5!?

I also considered:

13...h5 14.cxd5 cxd5 15.♖a4! shows one of the benefits of the bishop on f3: the e2-pawn is protected! 15...♙b7 16.h3 g5 17.hxg4 gxf4 18.♖xf4 Black is a pawn down with an exposed king.

13...f5 14.exf6 ♘xf6 15.♘d2 ♙d6 16.♙xd6 ♖xd6 17.♖a1 White has the more comfortable position, and will soon carry out e2-e4 to attack Black's centre.

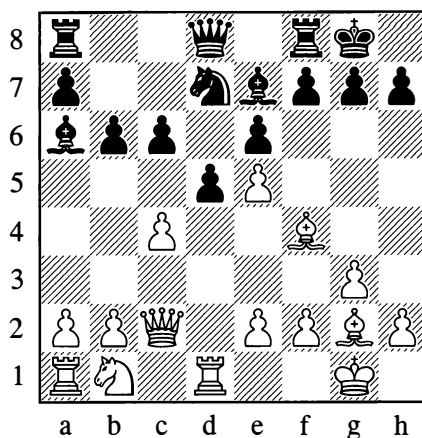


14.♙xg4 gxf4 15.♘d2

The position is complicated, but I like White's chances. An illustrative variation is:

15...♙h8 16.cxd5 cxd5 17.♖a4 fxg3! 18.hxg3! ♙b7 19.♙g2!

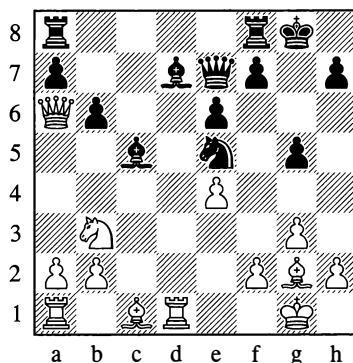
The open h-file might turn into a serious headache for Black.



13.cxd5 cxd5 14.e4 ♖c8

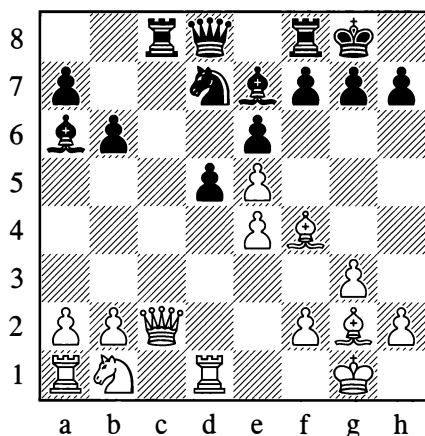
14...g5? is poor, and after 15.♙e3 ♘xe5 16.exd5 ♖c8 17.♘c3± Black had no compensation for having weakened his kingside in Wojtkiewicz – Kustar, Sioux Falls 2000.

14...d4 15.♖xd4 ♙c5 (15...♖c8 16.♘c3 transposes to the main line below) 16.♖d1 g5 17.♙c1 ♖e7 Black is about to regain the e5-pawn, but White has just enough time to get active. 18.♖a4 ♙c8 19.♘d2 ♘xe5 20.♘b3 ♙d7 21.♖a6 Despite the material equality, Black's position is rather unpleasant, as the following game illustrates.



21...♖ad8 (21...f6N is a better try, although 22.♘xc5 ♖xc5 23.♙e3± still favours White) 22.♘xc5 ♙c8 23.♖e2 ♖xd1† 24.♖xd1 bxc5 25.♖d2 f6 26.♖c3± White clearly had the

better game in Tkachiev – Filippov, Fuegen 2006.



15.♖c3 d4

This pawn sacrifice is forced. Black hopes to obtain compensation due to the doubled pawns in the centre. An important point is that the e4-pawn blocks both the Catalan bishop and the knight's route towards d6.

15...dxe4?N is effectively refuted by 16.♙a4! ♙d3 17.♘xe4 b5 18.♙xa7 ♖c7 19.♙e3 when Black is a pawn down anyway, but under highly unfavourable circumstances.

16.♙xd4 ♙c7

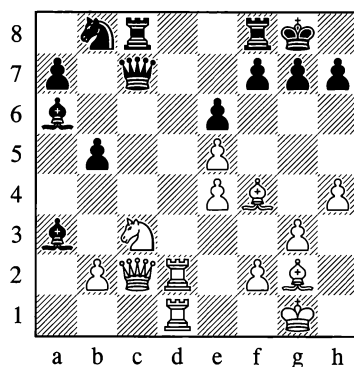
This is the main line.

Nakamura once experimented with 16...♙c5?! in a blitz game. Despite his eventual victory, there is no doubt that after 17.♙d2 ♙b7 18.♙ad1 ♙c6 19.h4 ♙e7 20.a3 a5 21.♘a4!± his position was poor in Gelfand – Nakamura, Moscow (blitz) 2010.

17.♙ad1 ♙fd8

Please note that 17...♘xe5?? is refuted by 18.♙a4! ♙b7 19.♙d7.

One game continued 17...♘b8 18.h4 b5 19.a3 ♙c5 20.♙d2 ♙xa3, and now a clear improvement is:



21.♙b3!N (After 21.bxa3 ♙xc3 22.♙xc3 ♙xc3 23.♙e3 ♘c6 Black was okay in Verat – Shchekachev, Paris 2001) 21...♙c5 (An important point is that 21...♙xb2 runs into 22.♘d5! exd5 23.♙xb2 dxe4 24.e6 with a decisive initiative) 22.♘xb5 ♙b7 23.♙f1± White still has an extra pawn and his pieces are much more active.

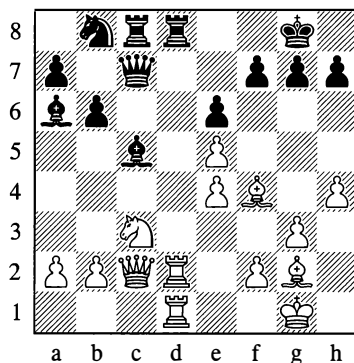
18.h4

It is essential to prevent ...g5.

18...h6

This has been the clear first choice, but I would like to mention two other possibilities.

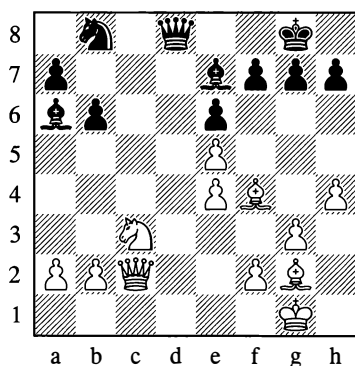
18...♙c5 19.♙d2 ♘b8 was played in Kengis – Kayumov, Arad Abudhabi 2003.



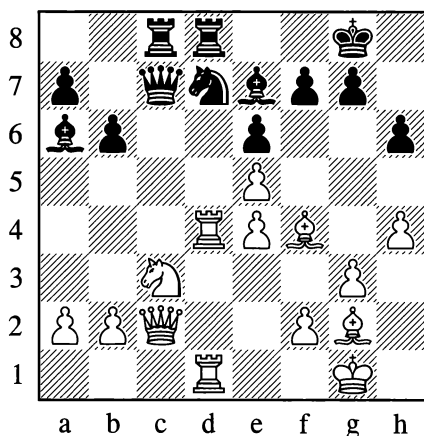
And now the simple 20.a3N would be a clear improvement, for example: 20...♙xd2 21.♙xd2 b5 22.♙b3 ♙b7 23.♘a2! ♙b6 24.♘b4 ♙b7

25.♘d3 ♕d4 26.♚d1± White keeps an extra pawn plus a space advantage.

18...♘b8 19.♞xd8† ♞xd8 20.♞xd8† ♚xd8 occurred in Gelfand – Alekseev, Moscow 2008. The exchanges have removed the pressure from the e5-pawn, giving White an opportunity to free his bishop.



21.♙e3!N ♘d7 22.f4 ♘c5 23.♙f1! White has an obvious advantage.



19.h5

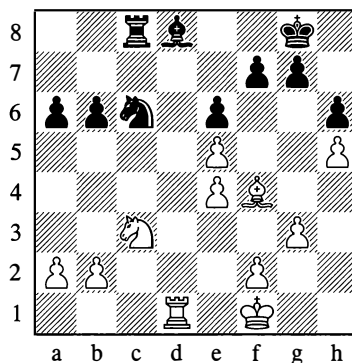
This ensures that White will never have to worry about ...g5 ideas, while also securing a space advantage on the kingside, which might be useful in a future endgame. We now have an interesting situation where Black is unable to recapture on e5 yet (as ♞xd8† followed by ♚a4 will be devastating), but White faces a

challenge over how to improve his position while maintaining the indirect defence of his extra pawn.

19...♙c5

Black has tried three other moves, all of which seem reasonably sensible.

19...♘b8 20.♞xd8† ♕xd8 21.♚a4! ♚c6 22.♚xc6 ♘xc6 23.♙f1 ♙xf1 24.♙xf1 a6 occurred in Colovic – Pogorelov, Sort 2009. It is understandable that Black wanted to take away the b5-square from the knight, but White could have exploited the last move as follows:



25.♘a4!N Black's queenside looks extremely vulnerable, for instance: 25...b5 26.♘c5 a5 27.♘b7 ♙b6 28.♞c1 ♞b8 29.♞xc6 ♞xb7 30.♙d2± White has excellent winning chances.

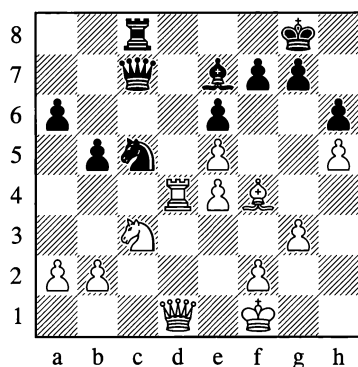
19...♘c5 20.♙f1! ♙xf1

Worse is 20...♙g5?! 21.♙xg5 ♞xd4 22.♞xd4 ♙xf1 23.♙f4 ♙a6 24.♚d1 ♚e7 25.♞d6± and White went on to win convincingly in Tkachiev – Jakovenko, Dresden 2007.

21.♙xf1 ♞xd4 22.♞xd4 a6

22...♘d7 23.♚a4! ♘c5 24.♚d1 ♚c6 occurred in Afanasiev – Demianjuk, Anapa 2012. Here White could have slowly improved his position by means of: 25.a3N b5 (25...a5? 26.a4!±) 26.b4 ♘a6 27.♙d2± Followed by f2-f4, with the better game.

23.♚d1 b5



24.a3!N

Improving over the hasty 24.b4 ♘b7 25.♞d7 ♞c4†! 26.♞e2 ♙xb4 when Black was fine in Kobo – Baert, Gibraltar 2014.

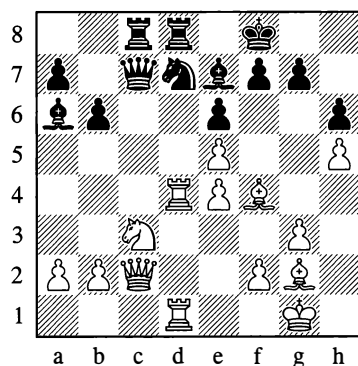
24...♞d8

I also considered 24...♞c6 25.b4 ♘b7 26.♙d2 and White slowly improves.

25.♞xd8† ♙xd8 26.♞d6! ♞c8 27.♙g2

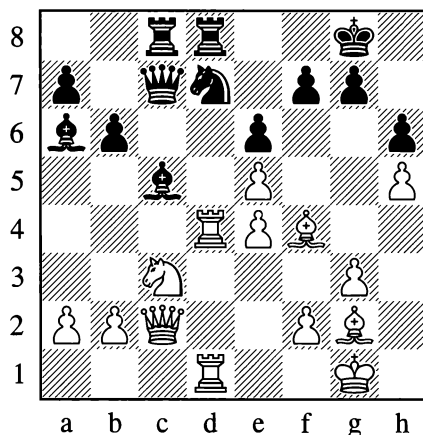
Black is a long way from equality.

19...♙f8!? is partially a waiting move, but it also serves a specific purpose, as shown in the next note. I propose:



20.♞4d2!N (In the only game to feature Black's last move, White played the hasty 20.♙f1, and after 20...♙xf1 21.♙xf1 ♘xe5! 22.♞xd8† ♞xd8 23.♞xd8† ♙xd8 24.♞a4 ♙f6 Black had equalized in Kovalenko – W. Zhou, Moscow 2011. Black's 19th move served an important function in covering the e8-square.) After the text move Black may play 20...♙g8!?, which

transposes to the main line below. Other moves are possible, but White's general ideas remain the same as in other lines. However, it should be noted that 20...♘xe5? still does not work in view of 21.♞xd8† ♞xd8 22.♞xd8† ♙xd8 23.♞a4 ♙c8 24.♘b5± winning pawn.

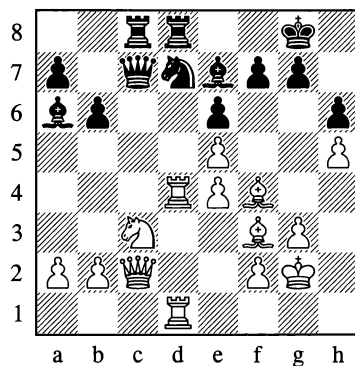


20.♞4d2 ♙e7

Now we face an interesting question: how should White improve his position if Black just sits and waits? I have two possible solutions.

21.a3

21.♙f3 is another way to improve. White frees the g2-square for the king, keeping in mind the possibility of a future g4-g5 push. 21...♙f8 22.♙g2 ♘g8N 23.♞d4!? Preparing ♙e2, while also setting up some possible tactics:



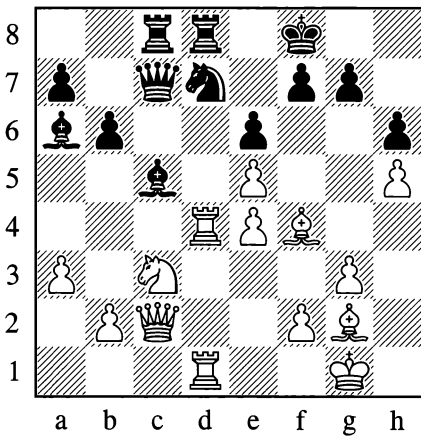
23...♙c5 24.♘d5! ♚b7 (In the event of 24...exd5 25.♙xd5 ♘f8 26.♙xd8 ♙xd8 27.b4! White is much better) 25.♙d2!± Black is under some pressure.

21...♙f8

After 21...♘c5?! 22.♙xd8† ♙xd8 23.♙f1 White significantly improves his position.

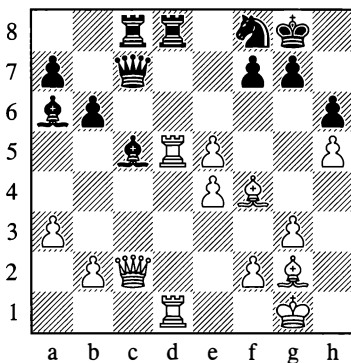
22.♙d4 ♙c5

Now in Vitiugov – Tomashevsky, Moscow 2008, White settled for the draw. However, I discovered an interesting way to play for more.



23.♙d6!?N ♙xd6

23...♙g8 can be met by the thematic 24.♘d5!?, when the following line is more or less forced: 24...exd5 25.♙6xd5 ♘f8



26.b4! ♙xf2† 27.♙xf2 ♘e6 28.♙f3± White

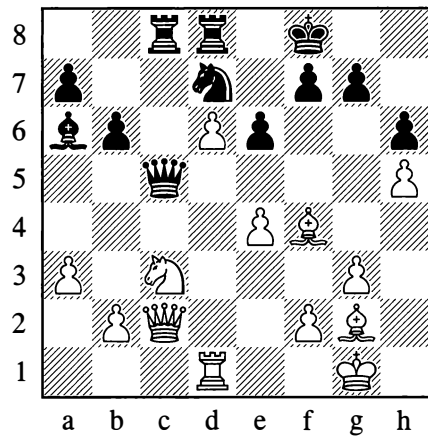
retains an extra pawn plus the initiative, and can increase the pressure with moves like ♙d6 and ♙h3.

24.exd6

White enjoys rich compensation thanks to his strong passed pawn and pair of bishop.

24...♙c5

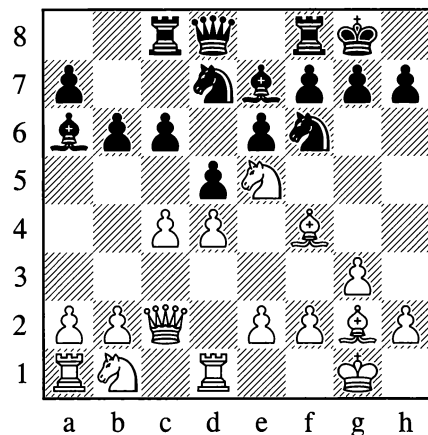
I also considered 24...♙b8 25.e5 ♘g8 26.♙e4 ♙c5 27.♙c1 ♙c8 (after 27...♙dc8 28.♙e3 the rook is in danger on c5) 28.♙f3 with long-term compensation.



25.e5 ♘g8 26.♙e1 ♙d4 27.♙c1

White remains in control, and has more than enough compensation for the exchange.

C13) 11...♙c8

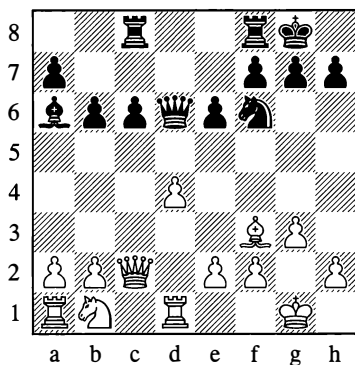


12.cxd5!

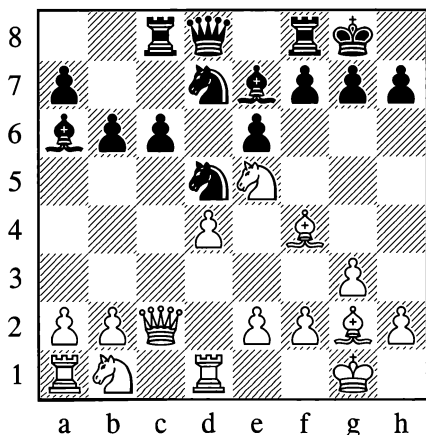
I believe this is the only way to fight for the advantage. 12.♘c3 is more popular and has scored better, but after 12...♙xc4 13.♘xc4 dxc4 14.e4 b5! I believe Black is doing well.

Black may recapture with **C131) 12...♘xd5** or **C132) 12...cxd5**.

12...♘xe5N has not yet been tested. White should react with 13.d6! (Surprisingly, 13.dxe5 ♘xd5!? 14.e4 ♘xf4 15.♙xd8 ♘e2† 16.♙h1 ♙fxd8 is not so clear) 13...♘f3† 14.♙xf3 ♙xd6 15.♙xd6 ♙xd6



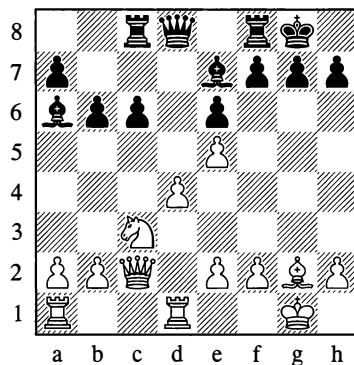
16.♙a4!? ♙b5 The only move. 17.♙b3 ♙a6 (17...e5 18.dxe5 ♙xe5 19.♘c3± is unpleasant for Black) 18.♘c3 White has the more pleasant position. An important point is that 18...c5?? is refuted by 19.♙a3! when the bishop has nowhere to go.

C131) 12...♘xd5**13.♘c3**

White should refrain from 13.♘xc6 in view of: 13...♘b4! 14.♙a4 ♘xc6 15.♙xa6?!N (15.♙xc6 is objectively better, although 15...♙xe2 16.♙e1 b5! 17.♙xa7 ♙xc6 18.♙xe2 ♘f6± still gave Black a great game in Krotov – Shkuro, Azov 2010) 15...♘c5! 16.♙c4 ♘a5 White will have to fight for a draw by giving up his queen for some pieces.

13...♘xe5

13...♘xf4 14.gxf4 gives White a good version of a well-known pawn structure. I only found one example from here, which continued: 14...♘xe5 15.fxex5 White intends to fortify his central position with f2-f4 and e2-e3.



15...b5? A bad positional error, restricting the light-squared bishop. Now in Gleizerov – Rigo, Banska Stiavnica 2010, White could have played 16.a3N± followed by b2-b4, with a serious positional advantage.

14.♙xe5

14.dxe5 ♙c7 is nothing for Black to worry about.

14...♘xc3 15.bxc3 ♙c4!

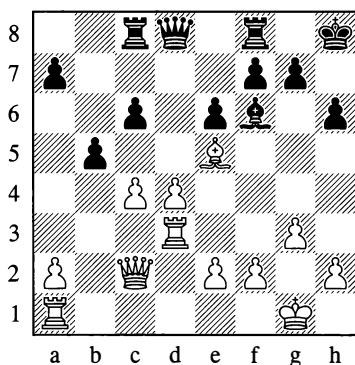
Otherwise White will play c3-c4, claiming an obvious positional advantage.

16.♙e4

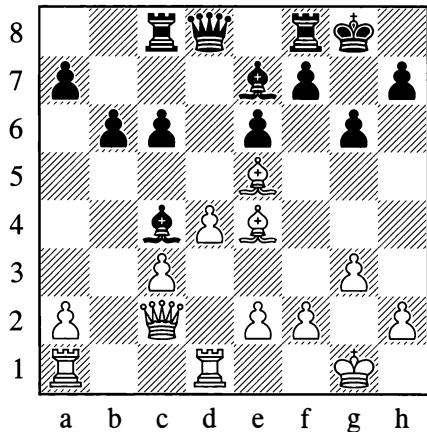
This is White's only challenging idea.

16...g6

An obvious alternative is: 16...h6 17.♙h7† ♜h8 18.♙d3 ♙xd3 19.♞xd3 b5 20.c4 ♙f6 This logical sequence occurred in Maletin – Volokitin, Moscow 2011. Now the natural continuation would have been:



21.c5!N a5 22.♞ad1 White retains an obvious positional edge.

**17.♙d3!N**

So far White has played 17.h4 in three games, all of which have been drawn. Clearly a fresh idea is needed, and I consider the text move the most promising new direction.

17...♙xd3 18.♞xd3 ♙f6 19.♞a4!

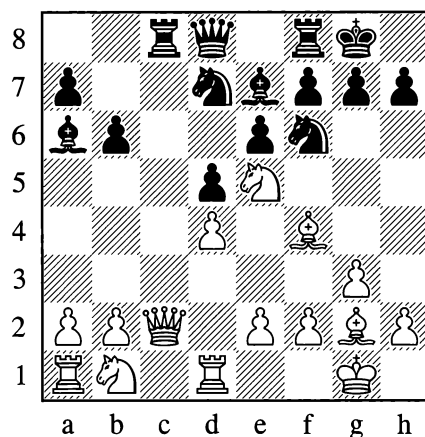
Without this important resource, I don't see anything special for White. Now it is not so easy for Black to defend the a-pawn.

19...a5

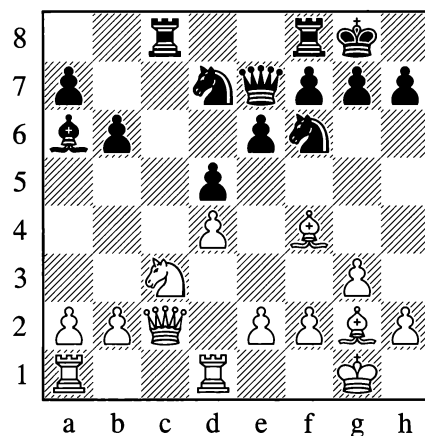
19...♙xe5 20.dxe5 ♞c7 21.♞d6! obviously favours White.

20.c4 ♙xe5 21.dxe5 ♞g5 22.f4 ♞f5 23.♞b3±

Black is under some pressure.

C132) 12...cxd5**13.♘c6**

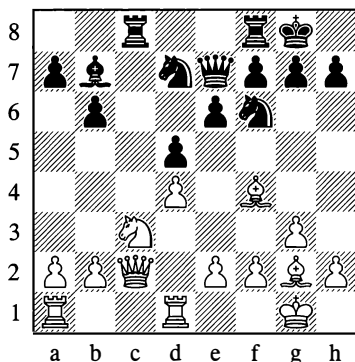
This is the main point of exchanging on d5. White will exchange on e7 and attempt to take advantage of the bishop pair. We will examine C1321) 13...♞e8, C1322) 13...♙b5 and C1323) 13...♘h5.

C1321) 13...♞e8 14.♘xe7† ♞xe7 15.♘c3

15...♘h5

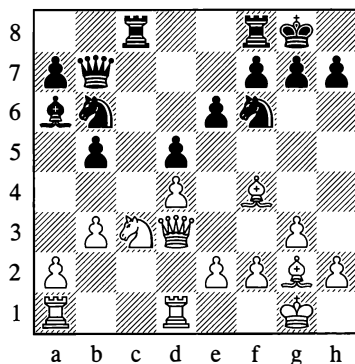
Other moves also fail to equalize:

15...♙b7 occurred in Naumann – Levin, Mulheim 2009.



I believe White should have taken the opportunity to control the f1-a6 diagonal right away with 16.♙d3N, for instance 16...a6 17.♙ac1 ♖c6 18.f3± and White is improving the position nicely.

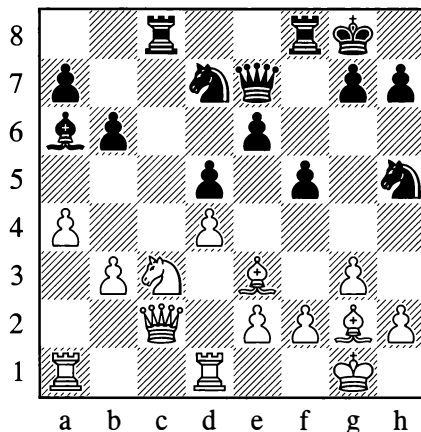
15...b5?! looks interesting at first sight, but after 16.♙d3! ♘b6 17.b3! it transpires that Black is in trouble. 17...♙b7 (17...b4N 18.♙xa6 bxc3 19.♙ac1± does not bring him any relief.)



18.♘xb5 ♘e4 19.♙dc1 ♙xc1† 20.♙xc1 ♙c8 21.a4 ♙xc1† 22.♙xc1 ♙c6 23.♙a3± White had won a pawn and smoothly executed his opponent in Le Quang Liem – Nabaty, Gibraltar 2012.

16.♙e3

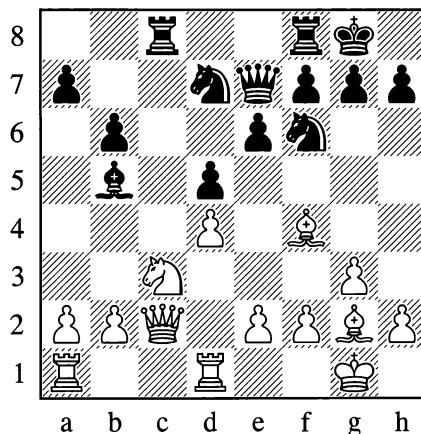
White has a typical slight edge, and it is only a matter of time before he gets his bishops working. In the one game from this position, Black soon went downhill.

16...♙c4?! 17.b3 ♙a6 18.a4 f5**19.♙c1!**

The bishop heads towards its best diagonal.

19...♙b4 20.♘a2 ♙d6 21.♙d2! ♙b7 22.♘c3 ♙b8 23.♙a3

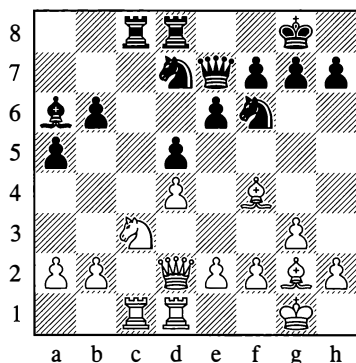
White was clearly better in Bacrot – Ibrahimov, Basel 2011.

C1322) 13...♙b5 14.♘xc7† ♙xc7 15.♘c3

So far Black has achieved solid practical results, drawing every game from this position. However, I believe in White's long-term chances with the bishop pair.

15...♞h5

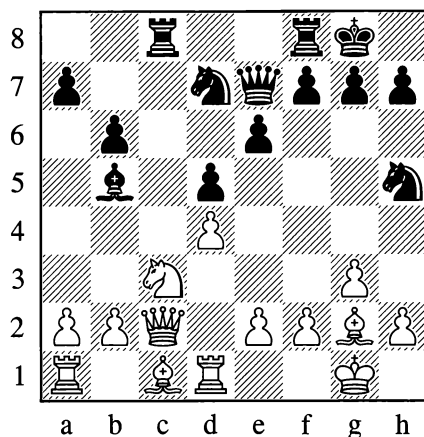
15...a5 is a logical move which has been played by Grischuk. Here I like the following idea: 16.♞d2 ♟a6 17.♞ac1 ♞fd8 (17...h6 18.f3 b4 19.h4 also favoured White in Stupak – Almasi, St Petersburg 2012) The present position was reached in Yefremov – Cleto, email 2011. Since Black's last move prepared the plan of ...♞f8-g6, I suggest countering with:



18.♟f3! ♞f8 19.g4! ♞g6 20.♟g3± White has preserved the bishop's placement on the optimal h2-b8 diagonal, while also gaining some space on the kingside. Later he may consider h4-h5 when the time is right. Overall White's advantage is not that large, but he maintains a pleasant pull.

16.♟c1!N

I find this new idea perfectly natural. The unopposed dark-squared bishop is key to White's opening strategy, and it makes sense to try and activate it via a3. White failed to impress after 16.♟e3 ♞hf6 17.♞d2 ♟a6 18.♟f4 ♞h5 19.♟g5 ♞hf6 when a draw was agreed in Wen – Yu, China 2014.



16...♞hf6 17.♞d2

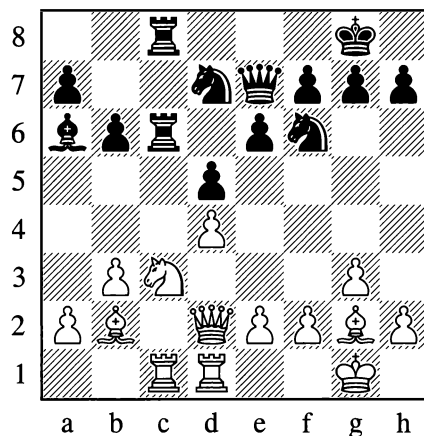
17.b3? allows 17...♟xe2! winning a pawn.

17...♟a6 18.b3 ♞c6 19.♟b2!

19.a4 is premature in view of 19...♞b4, and after the forced 20.♞a2 ♞xd2 21.♞xd2 ♞fc8 Black gets a lot of activity.

19...♞fc8 20.♞ac1

Even though the bishop has not yet made it to a3, White has still achieved a good level of harmony, and can aim to improve his position with f2-f3 and later e2-e4. Here is a brief illustrative line.

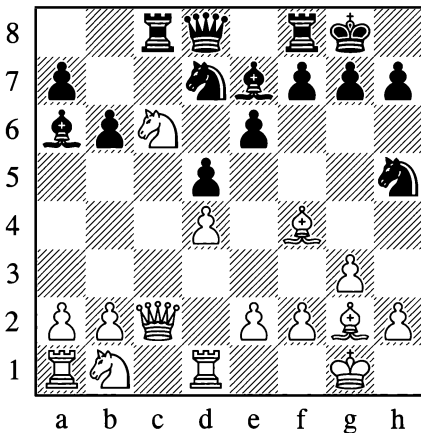


20...♞b4 21.f3 h6 22.♞c2

22.e4 is a bit premature due to 22...dxe4 23.fxe4 e5 when Black looks to be okay.

22...♙b7 23.e3±

Black has a solid position and his queen and rooks are active, but it is hard for him to threaten anything. Meanwhile White can continue making small improvements, with the e3-e4 advance being the primary objective.

C1323) 13...♖h5

This has been the most popular move.

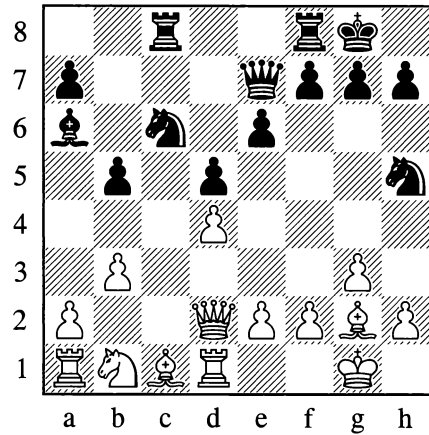
14.♙c1!

Once again, White should aim to post his bishop on a3. Amazingly, this strong move has only been played in one out of thirteen games on my database.

All the other games continued 14.♙e3 ♖b8! 15.♖xe7 ♜xe7 16.♖c3, after which Black has yet to lose a single game. 16...♖c6 looks like the most natural move, when Black is doing fine.

14...♖b8 15.♖xe7 ♜xe7 16.♜d2!

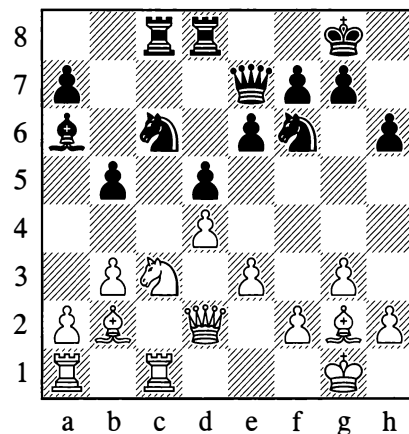
It makes sense to keep the knight on b1 for the moment, in order to facilitate the plan of b2-b3 and ♙a3.

16...♖c6 17.b3 b5**18.♙b2N**

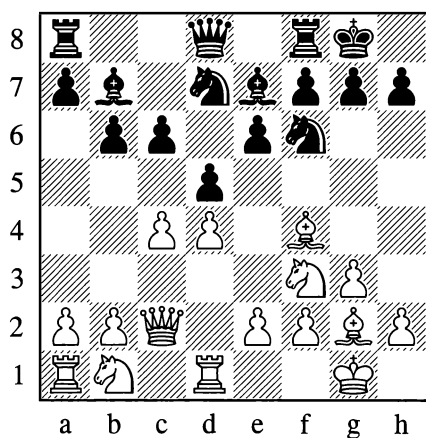
This simple move seems more promising than 18.a3 ♖f6 19.♖c3 ♜c7 20.♖a2 ♜b6 21.♜b2 h6 22.♙f4 ♜fd8 23.♖b4 (23.♜ac1 ♙b7) 23...♖xb4 24.axb4 ♙b7 25.♜ac1 ♖d7 when White could hardly improve his position in Leko – Ponomarev, Saratov 2011.

18...♖f6

18...b4? runs into 19.a3! ♖a5 20.♜e3 ♜c2 21.♖d2± when Black is in trouble.

19.♖c3 ♜fd8 20.♜dc1 h6 21.e3±

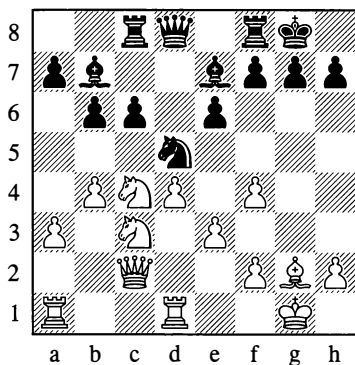
Taking into account that ...b4 would be a positional error, Black has to remain with the pawn on b5, which makes his position feel rather awkward. White is undoubtedly slightly better.

C2) 10...♙b7

This has been the most popular choice. The bishop is slightly less active here than on a6, but it supports the c6-square and the centre in general.

11.♘e5!

I have chosen to depart from the recommendation in *GM 1* at a relatively early stage. It is worth briefly mentioning the problem I found: 11.♘c3 dxc4 12.♘d2 ♘d5 13.♘xc4 ♘xf4 14.gxf4 ♘f6 15.e3 ♘d5 16.a3 ♙c8 17.b4 I considered this position to be rather promising for White, but in the following game Black came up with an excellent plan:

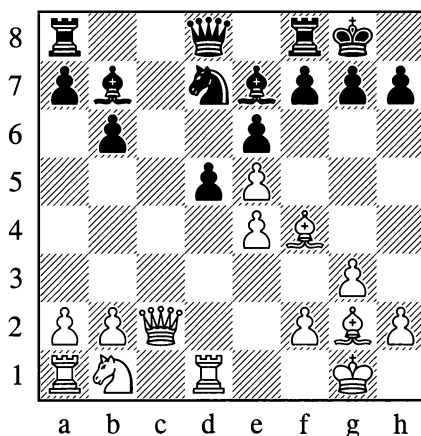


17...f5! By fixing the pawn structure, Black gets significant chances to seize the initiative

on the kingside by means of ...g5 or ...♙f6-h6. The stem game continued 18.♙ac1 g5 19.fxg5 ♙xg5 20.f4 ♙f6 21.♙f2 ♙c7 22.♘e2 ♘h8 and Black was at least not worse in Gupta – Maiorov, Metz 2011.

Black may react to my recommended move with C21) 11...♘xe5, C22) 11...♘h5, C23) 11...b5 or C24) 11...♙c8.

**C21) 11...♘xe5 12.dxe5 ♘d7
13.cxd5 cxd5 14.e4**

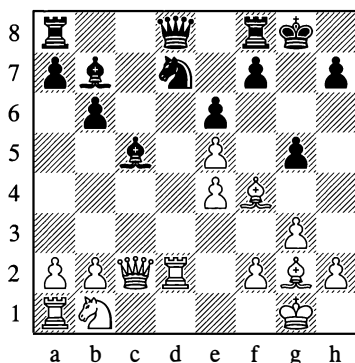


The position bears an obvious similarity to the earlier variation C12, but this time Black is not forced to sacrifice a pawn.

14...dxe4

I believe this is Black's best bet. He has two other reasonable options at his disposal:

14...d4 15.♙xd4 ♙c5 16.♙d2!N (This is an obvious improvement over 16.♙d1 g5! 17.♙c1 ♙e7 18.♘d2?! ♘xe5 19.♘b3 ♙ad8 when Black was perfectly fine in Anwesh – Sethuraman, Porto Carras 2010) 16...g5 (In the event of 16...♙e7 17.♘c3 ♙fd8 18.♙ad1± White comfortably retains his extra pawn.)



17.♙d1! It is not just the second rook that can utilize the d1-square! 17...♙c6 (17...gxf4 18.♙xd7 ♙c8 19.gxf4±) 18.♙g4 ♙e7 19.h4 White has a powerful attack in addition to his extra pawn.

14...♙c8 15.♙c3 d4

Black has also tried this familiar pawn sacrifice, just like in the earlier variation with the bishop on a6.

15...dxe4?! 16.♙xe4 ♙xe4 17.♙xe4 clearly favours White, for instance: 17...♙c7 18.♙b5 ♙c5 19.♙f3 ♙b8 20.b4 ♙a6 21.♙d6± White was dominating in V. Mikhalevski – Vescovi, Sao Paulo 2002.

16.♙xd4 ♙c5

16...♙c7 has been played, but it was practically refuted after: 17.♙e2 a6 (17...♙xe5 18.♙b5 ♙b8 19.♙xa7 wins a pawn) 18.♙d5! exd5 19.exd5 ♙c5 20.♙dd1! White had a huge initiative for the sacrificed piece in Terreaux – Aiken, corr. 2012.

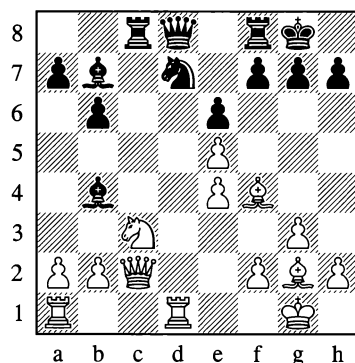
17.♙dd1

I like this move, although 17.♙d2 also looks promising.

17...♙b4

17...♙c6 18.♙d2 ♙c7 runs into the familiar 19.♙d5! exd5 20.exd5 with a decisive advantage.

Now in Bugalski – Mallek, Solec Kuj 2003, White missed a strong continuation:

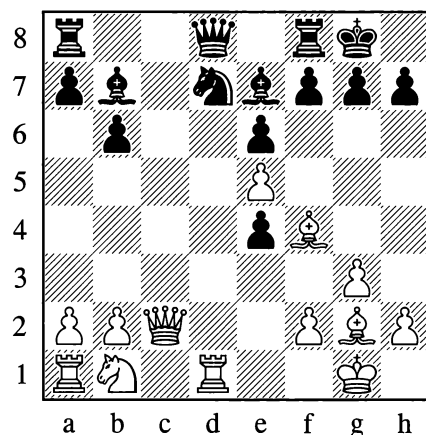


18.♙a4! N ♙xc3 19.♙xd7 ♙e8 20.♙d1!

It is easy to overlook such a move.

20...♙c6 21.♙xa7 ♙xb2 22.♙b1

White is clearly better.



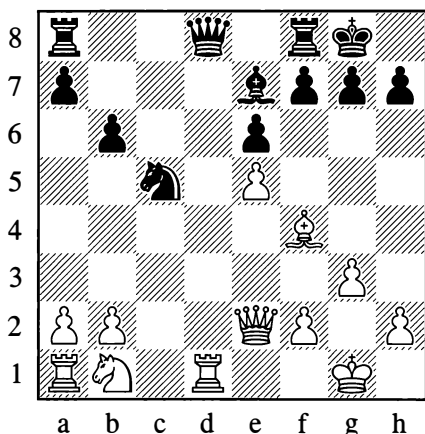
15.♙xe4 ♙xe4 16.♙xe4 ♙c5!

This is obviously better than 16...♙c7 17.♙c3 ♙ad8, when the active 18.♙b5 ♙b8 19.b4! ♙fe8 20.♙d4 ♙f8 21.♙c6 ♙b7 22.b5 gave White a stable edge in Schreiner – Oparin, Athens 2012.

17.♙e2!

This is more accurate than 17.♙f3, after which Vladimir Kramnik convincingly demonstrated that Black has a reliable game: 17...♙e8 18.♙c3 (18.♙d2 ♙d8 19.♙e4 ♙b5 gives Black no problems) 18...♙a4! 19.♙xa4 ♙xa4 20.b3 ♙a3 21.♙d7 ♙c5 22.♙e2 a5

23.♞ad1 a4 The players soon agreed a draw in Giri – Kramnik, Dortmund 2011.

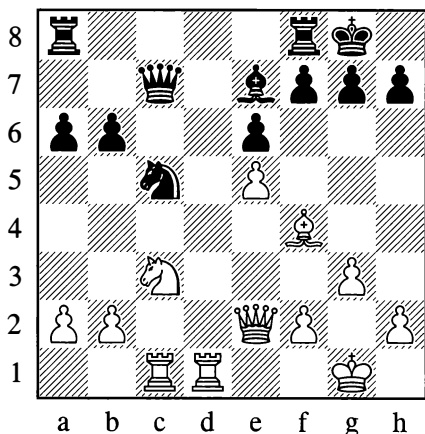


17...♞c7 18.♟c3 a6

Here another game pops up, which reached this position via a different move order. 18...♞ad8 19.♟b5 ♞c6 Now in Stachowiak – Grabarczyk, Wrocław 2013, White should have played 20.♟xa7!N, when 20...♞a4 21.♟b5 ♞xd1† 22.♞xd1 ♞xa2 23.♙e3 ♞b3 24.♟d6 leaves Black under some pressure. The knight is powerful on d6, and exchanging it would give White a dangerous passed pawn.

19.♞ac1

19.b4 would be met by 19...♟b3!.

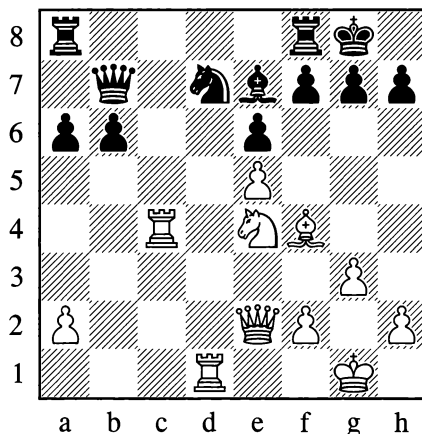


19...♞b7 20.b4 ♟d7 21.♟e4!?

This pawn sacrifice seems quite promising, but it is not essential. The calm 21.a3N is also fine, for instance 21...b5 22.♟e4 ♟b6 23.♙g5 ♙xg5 24.♟xg5 ♞ad8 25.♞d6! and White keeps a slight pull.

21...♙xb4 22.♞c4 ♙e7

In the event of 22...♙c5 23.♞g4 ♟h8 White can develop his initiative with: 24.♞h5! ♟g8 25.♟g5 h6 26.♟e4 f5 Otherwise ♙xh6 will decide the game. 27.exf6 ♟xf6 28.♟xc5 bxc5 29.♞e2± White regains the pawn and keeps the better chances thanks to his superior structure.



23.♟d6!N

This is my idea to improve over 23.♞cd4?! ♟c5 24.♟xc5 ♙xc5 25.♞d7 ♞c6 when White did not have enough compensation for the pawn in Meier – Schlosser, Belfort 2012.

23...♙xd6

If Black ignores the knight with 23...♞a7, then 24.♞c2 ♟c5 25.♙e3 sees White win back the pawn while retaining the better chances.

24.exd6 ♟c5 25.♙g5!

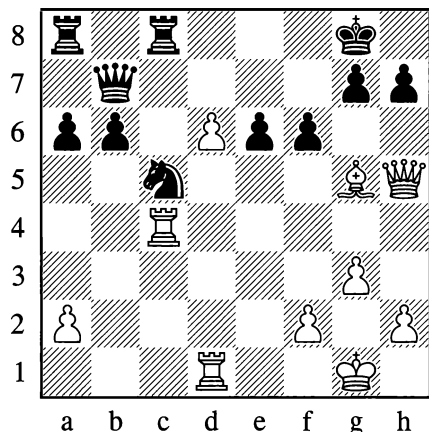
This strong move threatens to put the bishop on e7, while also clearing a path for the rook to go to the kingside, which may lead to a serious attack.

25...♟fc8

After 25...f6 26.♙e3± White regains the pawn and his mighty passed pawn should easily decide the game.

26.♞h5 f6

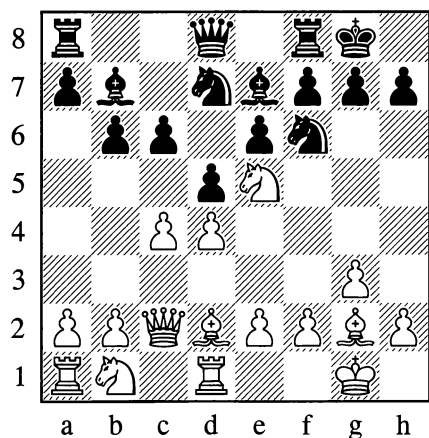
Otherwise ♞h4 will be hard to meet.

**27.♙xf6! ♖d7**

27...gxf6? 28.d7 ♖xd7 29.♞g4† ♔h8
30.♞f7 wins for White.

28.♞xc8† ♞xc8 29.♙b2

Material is equal, and White has an obvious advantage thanks to his powerful passed pawn and active pieces.

C22) 11...♖h5 12.♙d2 ♖hf6

I found more than sixty games from this position.

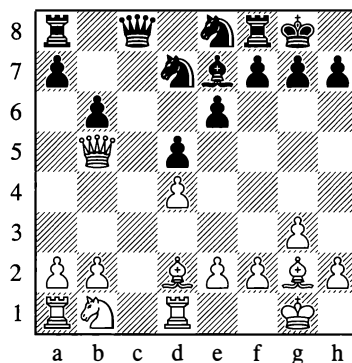
13.cxd5

I regard this as the only serious way to fight for the advantage. Not for the first time, White's strategy involves an early trade of a knight for an enemy bishop, followed by gradually improving his position.

13...cxd5 14.♖c6 ♙xc6 15.♞xc6 ♞c8

This has been the most popular choice, but it is worth mentioning some other moves:

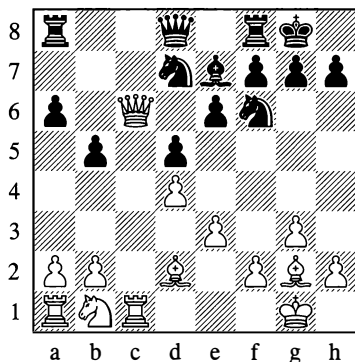
15...♞c8 has led to a couple of draws for Black, but it is not too hard to improve White's play.
16.♞b5 ♖e8



17.♞c1N (17.♖c3 ♖d6 18.♞d3 ♞c4 19.♞b1 ♖f6 20.e3 ♞c6 21.♙e1 ♟fc8 22.♞c1 ♞b7 was nothing special for White in Artemiev – Movsesian, Loo 2014) 17...♖d6 18.♞d3 ♞b7 19.♖c3 ♖f6 20.♞c2 ♞ac8 21.♞ac1 We have reached a normal type of middlegame with a lot of play ahead, where White's bishop pair makes him the slight favourite.

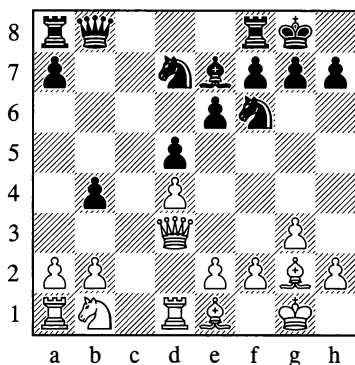
15...a6 16.e3 b5 is sensible, placing the pawns on the opposite colour to the remaining bishop. I think White's most interesting continuation is: 17.♞c1!N (17.♞c2 ♞c8 18.♞d3 ♞c4 19.♙f1 ♖e4 20.♙e1 led to a pleasant edge and an eventual win for White in Giri – Meier,

Dortmund 2011, but after the improvement 17...♘b6!?N 18.b3 b4 I think Black should be okay)



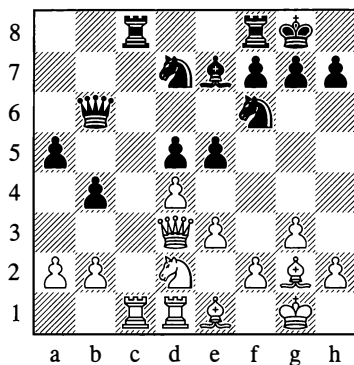
17...♘b6 (In the event of 17...b4 18.a3 a5 19.axb4 axb4 20.♖a6! White can develop his play on the queenside) 18.♙a5 ♘fd7 19.♘d2 ♗b8 20.♗c2 ♝c8 21.♗d1 White has the slightly better prospects; his bishop pair may prove crucial in the long term.

15...♗b8 has also been played at the elite level. 16.♗c2 b5 17.♗d3 b4 18.♙e1

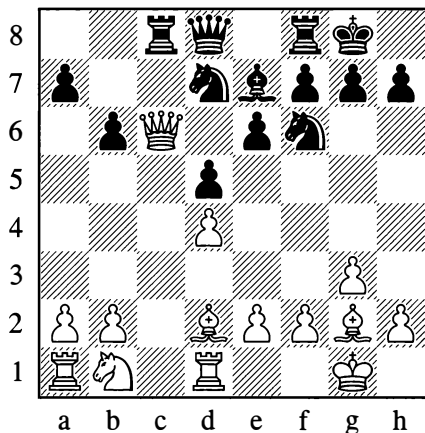


This move offers a convenient way of developing the knight to d2, which is obviously necessary after Black's last move. 18...♗b6 (In the event of 18...e5 19.♘d2 e4 20.♗a6! White clearly has the better game) 19.♘d2 a5 20.♖ac1 ♝ac8 21.e3 e5 (After 21...♖c6 22.♙f1 ♖fc8 23.♖xc6 ♗xc6 24.♗b5 ♗a8 25.♖b1± White slowly starts to take over on the queenside)

It is understandable that Black wanted to create some counterplay in the centre, but his last move makes White's light-squared bishop a more dangerous piece. In Caruana – Gelfand, Zürich 2013, White could have obtained a big advantage with:



22.♙f1!N e4 (22...exd4 23.exd4 ♖fe8 24.♘f3 ♙d6 25.♗a6±) 23.♗a6 ♗xa6 24.♙xa6 ♖a8 25.♙b5 Black is under pressure, for example: 25...♖fb8 26.♙f1 ♝c8 27.♘b3 a4 28.♘c5±



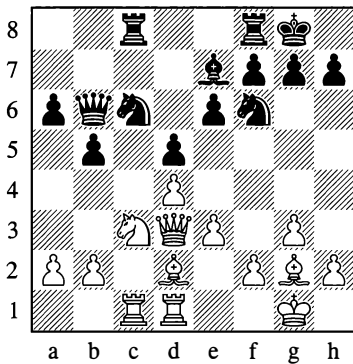
16.♗b5

16.♗a4 has been played a few times, including by Gelfand against Kramnik, but I am not so sure about the position after 16...♖c4!?N 17.♗xa7 ♖xd4 18.♘c3 ♖c4. My feeling is that the pawn trade has helped Black, who now boasts a central majority.

16...♘e8

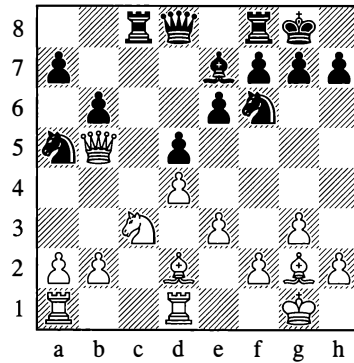
16...♘b8 has also been tried in several games. After the natural 17.♘c3 there are two main directions:

- a) 17...a6 18.♙d3 b5 Despite solid practical results for Black, advancing the queenside pawns is slightly risky, as it gives White a potential pawn lever on that flank. 19.♞ac1 ♘c6 20.e3 ♙b6

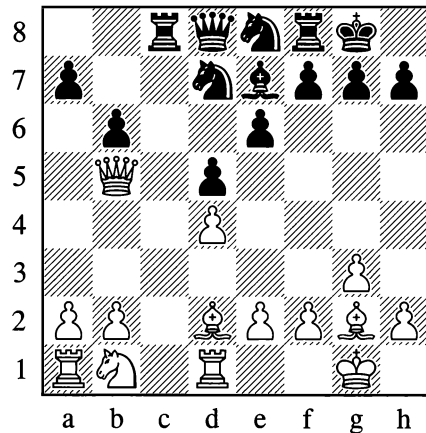


21.a4! Proving the above point. 21...b4 22.♘e2 ♙d6 23.♙f1 When the light-squared bishop starts to get active, it is generally an encouraging sign for White. 23...e5 As usual, aiming for central counterplay is natural, but there is an obvious risk that the light-squared bishop will become even more powerful. 24.dxe5 ♘xe5 25.♙f5± Acevedo Villalba – Muck, corr. 2011.

- b) 17...♘c6 18.e3 ♘a5 (18...♘e8 is a worse version for Black, as White can keep his queen more active: 19.♙a4! ♘d6 Now in Vorobiov – Clery, Cappelle la Grande 2013, the simple 20.♙e1!N ♙d7 21.♙f1 would have left White with an ideal position) At this point in Sasikiran – Alekseev, New Delhi 2012, White unnecessarily retreated his queen to e2. Instead I would prefer the more active alternative:



19.b3!N ♙a3 (19...♘b7 20.f3 ♘d6 21.♙a6 ♙d7 22.♞ac1 also favours White) 20.♞ab1 ♙e7 21.♘e2 ♙c7 (21...♞c2 runs into 22.♙a4! threatening b3-b4, and if 22...♞xa2 23.♘c3 ♞b2 24.♘b5 White has a big advantage) 22.♙e1 ♙e7 23.♞dc1± White is steadily increasing the pressure.

**17.♙d3**

17.♘c3 ♘d6 18.♙d3 is an equally acceptable move order.

17...♘d6 18.♘c3

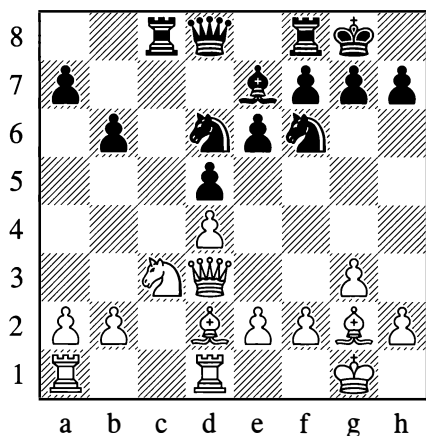
Here is an important point regarding move orders. 18.b3 has been played just as frequently as the text move, and sometimes transposes; it was even the choice of Caruana in both of the games mentioned below. However, I would argue that it is less accurate, as it allows Black the useful possibility of 18...♘b8! 19.♘c3

♘c6 20.e3 ♖d7, when he has regrouped his pieces harmoniously and has scored well in practice. For instance, after 21.♘e2 ♜c7 22.♝ac1 ♝fc8 Black had good prospects on the queenside and drew fairly effortlessly in Perez Ponsa – Illescas Cordoba, Tromso (ol) 2014.

18...♘f6

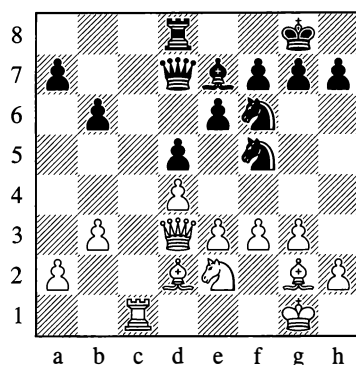
18...♘b8 has only been played in a single game, Sandipan – Wojtaszek, Jurmala (rapid) 2013. The difference from the previous note could have been emphasized by 19.e4!N, and after 19...dxe4 20.♘xe4 ♘xe4 21.♙xe4 h6 22.d5 the opening of the position makes White's bishop pair into a significant advantage.

18...♘c4 does not achieve much for Black. 19.♙c1 ♙b4 20.a3 ♙xc3 21.♖xc3 a5 occurred in Ilincic – Acs, Hungary 2008, and now the accurate 22.♖e1!N ♘d6 23.a4 ♘f6 24.b3 would have nullified Black's activity, leaving White with great long-term prospects with two bishops against two knights.



19.b3 ♖d7 20.f3 ♘f5 21.e3 h5

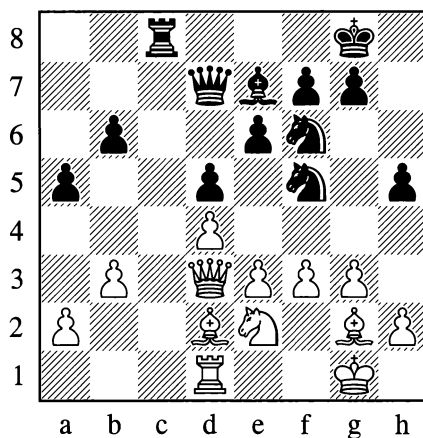
Surprisingly, this move has occurred in three games. Another example continued: 21...♝fd8 22.♘e2 ♖c7 23.♝ac1 ♖d7 24.♝xc8 ♖xc8 25.♝c1 ♖d7



26.a4 White slowly improves his position all over the board. 26...♙a3 27.♝c2 a5 28.♖a6 ♝b8 29.♘f4 ♙d6 30.♘d3± Black was still solid, but there is no doubt that White had made progress and enjoyed the better chances in Caruana – Yu Yangyi, Tromso 2013.

22.♘e2 ♝fd8 23.♝ac1 a5 24.♝xc8 ♝xc8

This position occurred in another game of the Italian superstar, Caruana – Nisipeanu, Bucharest 2013, which took place a couple of months after the aforementioned game against Yu Yangyi. I believe White should have kept one pair of rooks on the board, and continued to improve his other pieces. This could have been achieved by:

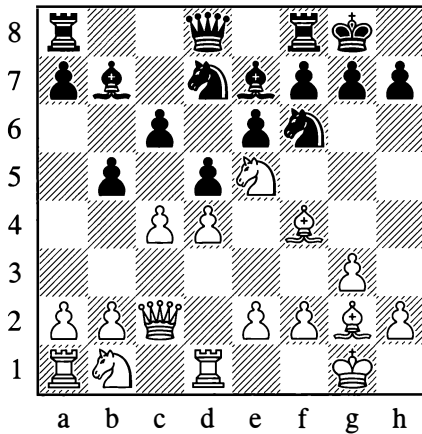


25.♙e1N ♝d8

Abandoning the open file is not ideal, but Black must be mindful of e3-e4.

26.♙f2 ♘d6 27.h3

White can continue preparing e3-e4 or g3-g4, with the aim of gradually opening lines for his bishop pair.

C23) 11...b5

This has still only been played in two games as yet, but it is quite challenging. The following analysis contains some instructive points which may prove useful in other positions involving a similar pawn structure.

12.♘xd7 ♘xd7 13.c5 g5!?

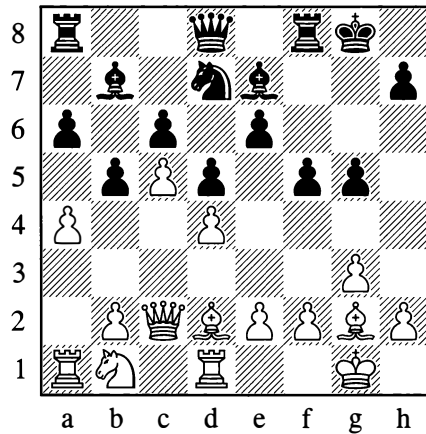
With the queenside more or less closed, it makes sense to gain some space on the kingside, and especially to prevent e2-e4.

14.♙d2

14.♙d6 looks tempting, but after 14...♙xd6 15.cxd6 ♗b8 I was unable to find any advantage for White.

14...f5 15.a4

It is essential to play this before Black has time for ...a5, which would prevent any future opening of the queenside.

15...a6**16.♙c3!N**

After 16.axb5 axb5 17.♗xa8 ♗xa8 18.♗c1 h6 19.h4 ♗d8 Black is just in time to hold the kingside together. 20.hxg5 hxg5 21.♘c3 ♗f7 22.♘a2 ♙f6 The position remains interesting, but it seems to me that Black was in good shape in Ovetchkin – Alekseev, Yekaterinburg 2013. The point of the text move is to maintain the tension on the queenside and bring more pieces into play before taking any direct action.

16...e5!?

This is the most principled reaction, though other moves can of course be considered. Here are a couple of examples:

After 16...a5 17.axb5 cxb5 we have the important resource 18.c6! ♙xc6 19.♙xa5 ♗c8 20.♗c1 ♗a6 21.♘d2 ♗fc8 22.♘b3 ♗b7 23.♗d2, when the opening of the queenside clearly favours White.

16...♘f6 17.♘d2 ♗c7 18.♘b3

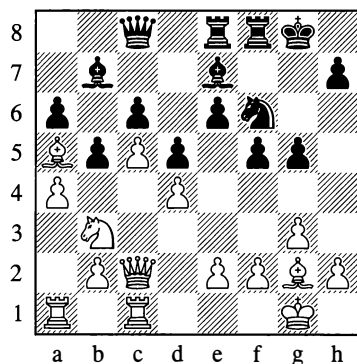
Black's passive light-squared bishop could become an important positional factor, but things are still not simple due to the closed nature of the position and the number of other pieces that remain on the board.

18...♗ae8 19.♙a5 ♗c8 20.♗dc1!

The point of this move is to prevent Black from recapturing on b5 with the c-pawn,

as can happen after 20.axb5 cxb5! 21.♙e1 ♖d7 22.♘a5 ♘b8, followed by ...♙c6, when White will have a hard time breaking through.

Now Black's queenside is under pressure, and his counterplay on the other flank might easily backfire, as the following line illustrates.

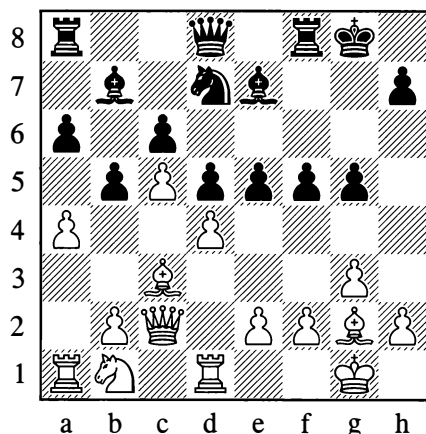


20...f4 21.axb5 axb5 22.♖d2!

Heading for f3.

22...♘g4 23.♖f3 fxg3 24.hxg3 ♖xf2 25.♙xf2 g4 26.♙h1 ♙f7 27.♙d2! gxf3 28.♙xf3

Black is vulnerable on the kingside.



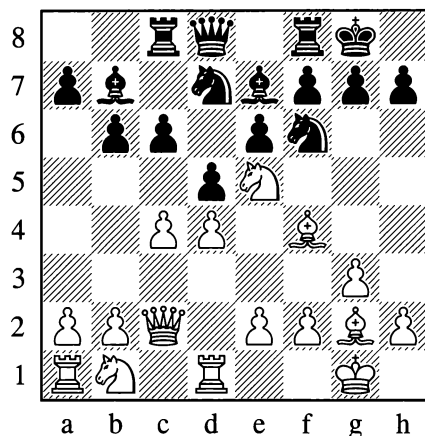
17.dxe5 ♖xc5 18.axb5 axb5 19.♖d2 g4

19...♖e6 20.b4 leaves White in control.

20.♙d4 ♖e6 21.♙xa8 ♙xa8 22.♖b3 ♙f7 23.e3

White has an obvious positional superiority.

C24) 11...♙c8



This position has occurred in more than sixty games, and the number jumps to more than a hundred after the transpositional effect of White's next move.

12.♖c3 ♖h5

This has been Black's most popular choice by far. It is worth mentioning a couple of alternatives:

12...♖xe5 13.dxe5 ♖d7 14.cxd5 cxd5 15.e4 transposes to a position covered earlier on page 215 – see 14...♙c8 15.♖c3 in the notes to variation C21.

12...b5 13.c5

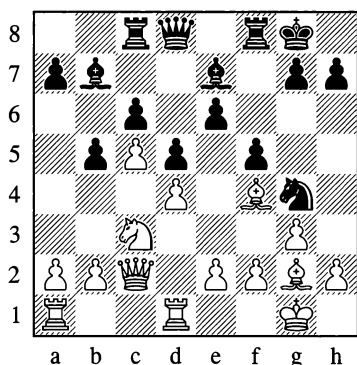
Once again, the blocked structure yields a slight plus for White.

13...♖xe5

Black can try to activate his problematic bishop by means of 13...b4 14.♖a4 ♖xe5 15.♙xe5 ♙a6, but the b-pawn makes an inviting target after 16.b3! ♙b5 17.a3, when White's queenside play gets underway.

14.♙xe5 ♖g4 15.♙f4 f5

Black must prevent e2-e4, and he should certainly avoid 15...e5? 16.dxe5 ♙xc5 17.♖e4! ♙e7 18.h3 when White has an overwhelming advantage, Aronian – Ghaem Maghami, Mainz 2010.



16.b4 a6

16...a5 is met strongly by 17.a4!, when the queenside opens up in White's favour.

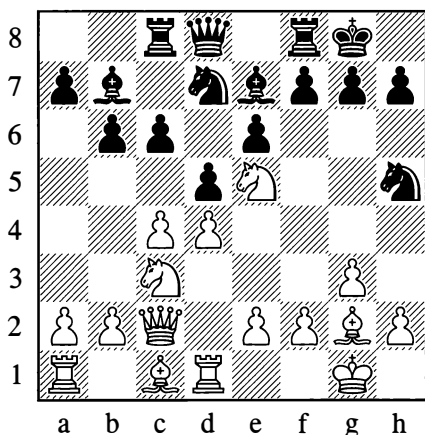
17.a4 ♖a8 18.♙a3 ♗d7 19.♘a2!

The knight is heading for d3 and e5.

19...g5 20.♙c1 ♜h8 21.♙b2 f4 22.h3 ♘f6 23.g4

The position remained tense but preferable for White in Avrukh – Sargissian, Gibraltar 2005. Black's light-squared bishop may prove to be a serious problem in the long run.

13.♙c1

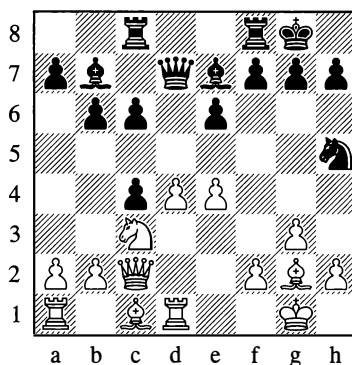


From this position **C241**) 13...f5 is a significant option, but the most popular choice has been **C242**) 13...♘hf6.

Another line worth mentioning is:

13...♗c7 14.♘d7 ♗xd7 15.e4 dxc4

15...♘f6 is definitely a concession and White is comfortably better after: 16.e5 (Maintaining the tension with 16.b3!?N also looks promising) 16...♘e8 17.♗a4! ♘c7 This position occurred in Shchekachev – Bunzmann, France 2002. The present moment would have been an appropriate time for the central exchange: 18.cxd5N exd5 19.♙e3! (19.♗xa7 ♙a6 20.♗xb6 ♗b8 21.♗a5 ♗a8 is rather unclear) 19...a5 20.♙ac1 White has a solid positional edge.



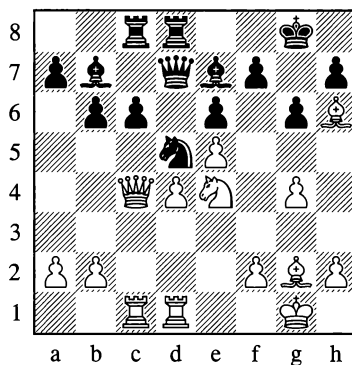
16.e5!N

White failed to impress after 16.♗e2 ♘f6 17.♗xc4 c5! 18.dxc5 ♗c7 in Ernst – Stohl, Germany 2007.

16...g6

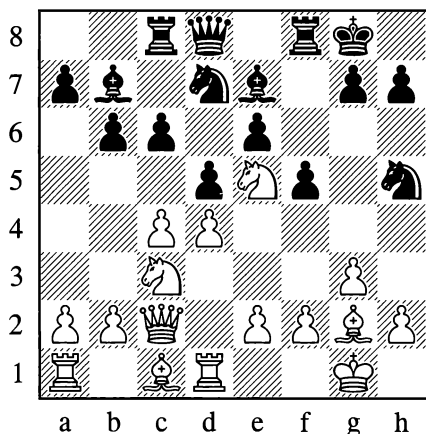
White's position is rich with potential. I like the following line:

17.♙h6 ♘g7 18.♗e2 ♗fd8 19.g4 ♘e8 20.♗xc4 ♘c7 21.♙ac1 ♘d5 22.♘e4



Material is equal and White remains more active.

C241) 13...f5

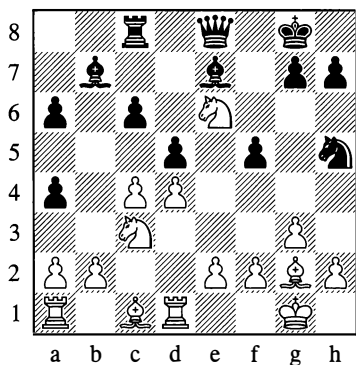


14. ♖a4!

A key move. If Black was given time to stabilize his position, he would be perfectly fine.

14...♘e5

14...a6 is risky: 15.♘xd7 b5 (Obviously Black cannot be satisfied with 15...♙xd7? 16.cxd5 exd5 17.♘xd5 when he was just a pawn down in Slavin – Almond, Newport Pagnell 2010) 16.♘xf8! The key point. 16...bxa4 17.♘xe6 ♗e8

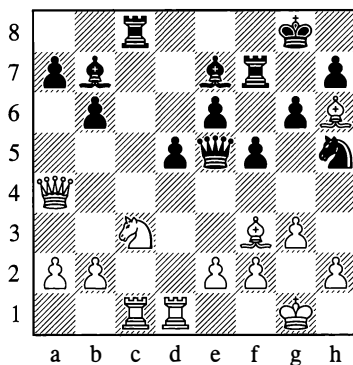


All this happened in Wojtaszek – Korobov, Warsaw 2013. At this point the simple

18.♘xa4N dxc4 19.♘ec5 ♙a8 20.♙d2 would have given White a clear positional plus, as he has full material parity for the queen while Black is pretty much playing without his light-squared bishop.

15.dxe5 a6

Black has also tried: 15...♙c7 16.♙f3 g6 17.♙h6 ♖f7 (17...♘g7 does not change much, for instance: 18.♖ac1 ♙b8 19.e3 ♖f7 20.h4 a6 21.♙b3 b5 22.cxd5 cxd5 23.♙f4±) 18.♖ac1 ♙xe5 19.cxd5 cxd5



20.♘xd5! ♙c5 (The knight is untouchable: 20...exd5? 21.♖xc8† ♙xc8 22.♙e8†+–) 21.b4! White was better in Hammer – Clery, Cappelle la Grande 2010.

16. ♙b3 b5 17.e4!

I found this strong idea in 2004. It is a clear improvement over 17.cxd5 cxd5 18.♙e3 f4! when Black had real counterplay in Van Wely – Spassky, France 2002.

17...fxe4

17...dxc4? is impossible in view of 18.♖xd8 cxb3 19.♖d7! and Black loses one of his bishops.

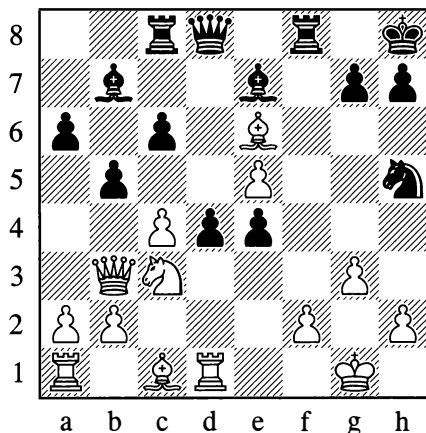
18. ♙h3! ♙h8

18...♙d7? is refuted by 19.cxd5 cxd5 20.♘xd5 ♙xd5 21.♖xd5! and White crashes through.

19.♙xe6 d4

Another important point is that 19...♙c5 does not work in view of 20.♘xe4 dxe4 21.♗xd8 ♙xf2† 22.♖g2 ♜cxd8 23.♙e3 and White wins.

This position occurred in Skoberne – Predojevic, Plovdiv 2008. Here White should have played:

**20.♙xc8!N**

The weakness of the light squares will not be a serious problem, as Black is unable to get his pieces into the necessary positions to take advantage.

20...♙xc8

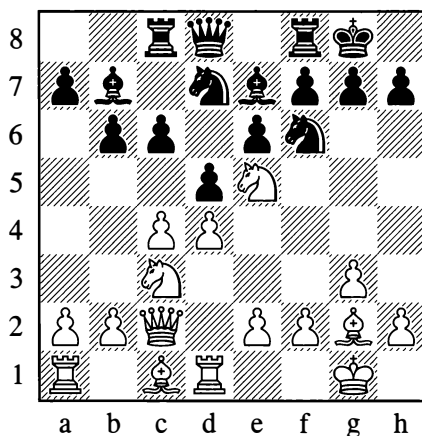
After 20...♙xc8 21.♗xd4 ♙c5 White simply returns the exchange with 22.♙e3 ♙xd4 23.♙xd4 c5 24.♙e3, keeping an extra pawn and a clear advantage.

21.♘xe4 ♙g4 22.cxb5 axb5 23.♗e1

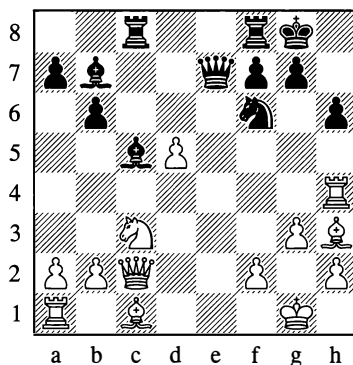
Black does not enough compensation, and White should win with careful play.

C242) 13...♘hf6

Chasing the bishop away and returning with the knight to f6 is a thematic occurrence in the Catalan.

**14.e4 dxc4**

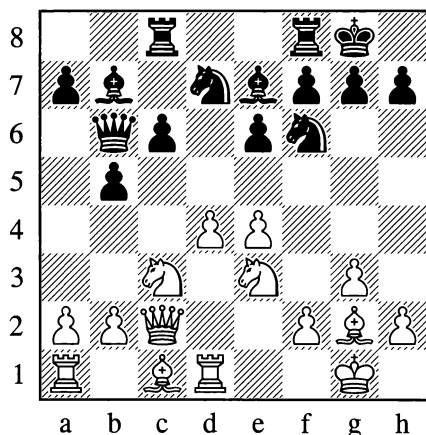
Black does not have much to offer aside from this move. It is worth mentioning the tricky 14...c5!? 15.exd5 cxd4 16.♘xd7 ♙xd7 17.♗xd4 exd5 18.cxd5 ♙c5 19.♗h4 h6 20.♙h3 ♙e7, when Black exploited some subsequent inaccuracies and scored a quick win in Lingnau – Farago Hungary 1993. However, at this point White could have established his superiority with:



21.♙xc8!N (Accepting the exchange sacrifice is inadvisable: 21.♙xc8? ♙e1† 22.♖g2 ♜xc8 and White's pieces are completely uncoordinated) 21...gxf6 22.♙d2 ♘h7 The only move. 23.♗e1 ♙f6 24.♘e4 ♙g7 25.♙xc8 ♜xc8 26.d6 After this virtually forced sequence, White stands clearly better.

15.♘xc4 b5 16.♘e3 ♙b6

The only decent alternative is 16...♞e8 17.b3 ♙f8 18.♙b2, when Black hardly has anything better than 18...♞b6, transposing to the main line.



17.b3 ♞fe8

White is ready to meet 17...c5N with 18.d5.

The main alternative is: 17...♞fd8 18.♙b2 a6 (18...♙f8 looks too passive. 19.a4 a6 20.♞e2 This is a good square for the queen. 20...♙g6 21.h4 White was clearly better in Vaganian – Gyimesi, Antwerp 2008.) 19.♞e2 (It is also worth considering 19.♙e2!?, heading for f4) The only game from this position continued 19...♞e8, and after 20.♞ac1 ♙f8 21.e5! ♙d5 22.♙e4 White had a clear positional plus in Laznicka – F. Berkes, Paks 2010.

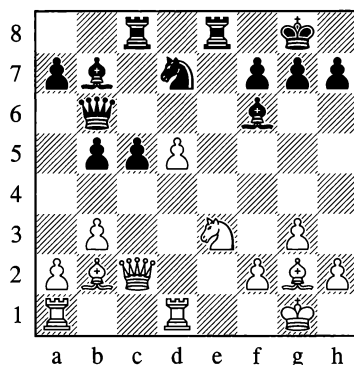
18.♙b2 ♙f8

This is a logical follow-up to Black's previous move. He has also tried striking in the centre:

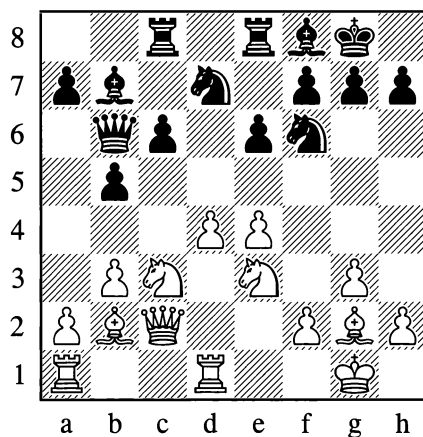
18...e5?! proved to be an unfortunate choice after 19.dxe5 ♙xe5 20.♙a4! bxa4 (20...♞c7 21.♙c5 is also not much fun for Black) 21.♙xe5 ♞c5 22.♙c3 and White was clearly better in Maletin – Pogorelov, Mumbai 2010.

18...c5 19.d5 exd5 20.♙cxd5 ♙xd5 21.exd5 ♙f6 (21...♙g5 is well met by 22.♞e1! when

the following example provides a convincing demonstration: 22...♙xe3 23.♞xe3 ♞xe3 24.fxe3 c4 25.♞d2 f6 26.♙d4 ♞d6 27.bxc4 ♞xc4 28.♙xa7! ♙c5 29.♞d1 Black was unable to demonstrate compensation for the pawn in Terreaux – Barbalic, email 2011.) This position occurred in Dziuba – Tiviakov 2010. In order to fight for the advantage, White has to play:



22.♙xf6N ♙xf6 (White's task is easier after 22...♞xf6 23.a4 a6 24.♙h3! ♞ed8 25.axb5 axb5 26.♞e2±) 23.a4 a6 24.♞ac1 White retains a lot of pressure.



19.e5

I think this is the right moment to advance the e-pawn.

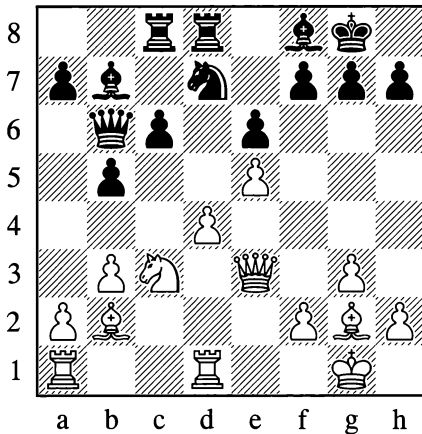
19...♙d5 20.♞d3

After 20.♘cxd5 cxd5 21.♚d2 b4 22.f4 f5! White did not have much in Rozum – Lafuente, St Petersburg 2010.

20...♘xe3

I also considered 20...a6 21.♞ac1 ♞ed8 22.♘e4 h6 23.♚e2 when White retains an edge. An important point is that 23...c5 can be met by 24.dxc5 ♘xc5 25.♙d4! with an advantage.

21.♚xe3 ♞ed8



22.a3!? c5

22...a5 is well met by 23.♘e4 with the following idea: 23...c5 24.dxc5 ♘xc5 25.b4 axb4 26.axb4 ♘a4 27.♙d4 ♚a6 28.♘d6±

23.d5

White was undoubtedly better in Muck – Rattinger, email 2007.

Conclusion

The set-up with ...c6 and ...♘bd7 presents a serious challenge, especially as the bishop on d2 prevents the otherwise desirable plan of ♘bd2 followed by e2-e4. After 9.♙f4 we reach our tabiya. The relative sidelines of 9...♘h5 and 9...a5 10.♞d1 ♘h5 should not be underestimated; the latter in particular has become quite popular, but I found some ways to put the black queenside under pressure by taking advantage of the weaknesses created by the ...a5 advance.

The main line is 9...b6 10.♞d1, when Black must decide where to develop his light-squared bishop. 10...♙a6 11.♘e5 is an important variation where Black has several options. The analysis of 11...♘xe5 runs quite deep, but in general White should be quite happy to play a position with an extra pawn, even if it is doubled on the e-file. The main line is 11...♞c8 12.cxd5! cxd5 13.♘c6, when White's strategy is simple: get coordinated and eventually exploit the bishop pair. It is worth remembering the idea of retreating the dark-squared bishop all the way to c1, in order to reroute it to the optimal a3-square.

The final part of the chapter covered 10...♙b7, when once again 11.♘e5! seems like the best way forward. The game is rich in possibilities, and White should be ready for various position types. After 11...♘xe5 12.dxe5, followed by cxd5 and e2-e4, he will have a space advantage and initiative in the centre. 11...♘h5 12.♙d2 ♘hf6 leads to a different situation where 13.cxd5 followed by ♘c6 forces the exchange of Black's light-squared bishop. Next we looked at 11...b5, when 12.c5 leads to another version of the blocked centre and queenside. And finally, the most popular 11...♞c8 12.♘c3 ♘h5 13.♙c1 reaches another thematic Catalan position where it seems to me that White keeps the better chances.